

Poor Man's Studio

Comprehensive User Guide

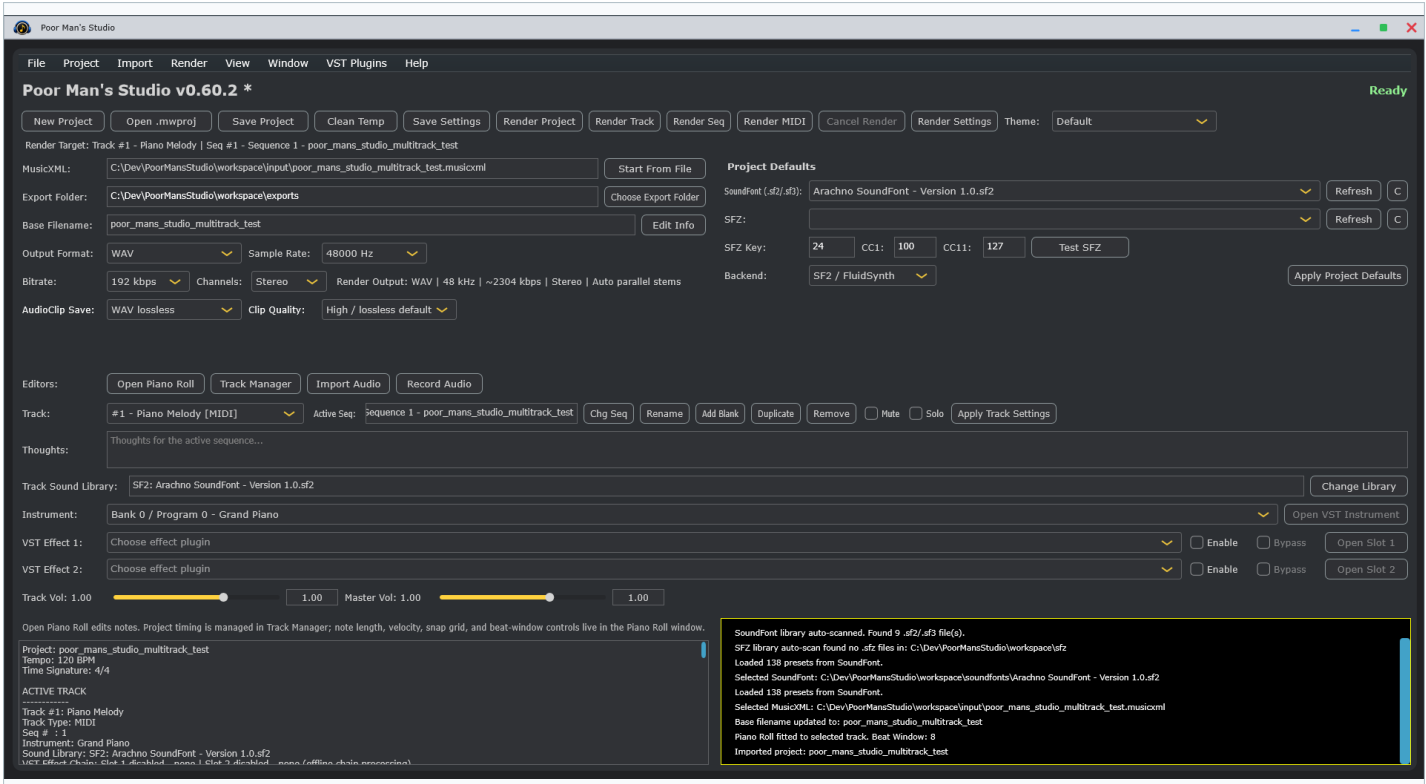


Figure 1. Main window overview.

Guide coverage

Guide area	Coverage
Screenshots	All 23 supplied PNGs are placed near their relevant guide sections.
Text	Detailed button, settings, workflow, troubleshooting, contents, and index coverage is retained.
Tables	Button/setting/workflow tables remain table-based for a professional reference layout.
Clickable navigation	The Contents and button/menu index include internal links.

Contents

Click a section title to jump directly to that part of the guide. Page numbers are intentionally omitted for now; linked page numbers can be added after layout is locked.

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Screenshot Coverage Map

Screenshot	Guide location / purpose
PMS_MainWindow.png	Cover and Main Window Reference
PMS_MenuFile.png	Starting Projects From Files / menu reference
PMS_MenuProject.png	Starting Projects From Files / project menu reference
PMS_MenuImport.png	Starting Projects From Files and AudioClip Import workflows
PMS_MenuRender.png	Preview, Render, Export, And Stems
PMS_MenuView.png	Settings, Themes, And Helper Bubbles
PMS_MenuHelp.png	Settings, Themes, And Helper Bubbles
PMS_MenuVSTPlugins.png	Button And Menu Index / VST workflows
PMS_MenuWindow.png	Window menu VST switchers
PMS_TrackManager.png	Track Manager And Arrangement Workflows
PMS_ChgColorSeqPicker.png	Track Manager / sequence picker workflow
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PMS_EditThoughts.png	Track Manager / notes workflow
PMS_PianoRoll.png	Piano Roll Editing
PMS_PianoRollPreviewPlayer.png	Piano Roll Preview Player
PMS_AudioClipRecorder.png	AudioClip Recorder Workflow
PMS_RenderSettings.png	Preview, Render, Export, And Stems
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PMS_VST3PluginManager.png	VST3 Plugin Manager And Instrument Hosting
PMS_VST3Settings.png	VST3 settings
PMS_VSTHostHelperStatus.png	VST host/helper status
PMS_VST3EffectsCustomTitleBar.png	Two-slot VST Effect Chain editor context
PMS_VST3InstrumentsCustomTitleBar.png	VST Instrument editor title/context

Poor Man's Studio - Comprehensive User Guide

1. Quick Start

Poor Man's Studio is a local Windows desktop music workstation for building and rendering small to medium music projects without requiring a full commercial DAW. It focuses on practical import, edit, preview, record, and render workflows using local tools such as FluidSynth, sfizz, FFmpeg, and optional VST3 plugins.

NOTE: The most important workflow rule is simple: Project Defaults affect new/imported MIDI tracks; Apply Track Settings commits changes to the selected track; Save Project commits project metadata and attached staged AudioClip media.

Fastest path from import to rendered audio

Step	Action	Why it matters
1	Choose project defaults: backend, library, instrument, base name, output format, sample rate, and channels.	These defaults are copied into future imported or newly added MIDI tracks.
2	Click Apply Project Defaults.	This is the commit point for project-level default choices.
3	Start from MusicXML, MXL, MIDI, audio, or an existing .mwproj project.	Poor Man's Studio creates tracks and sequences from the chosen source.
4	Choose a track and adjust instrument, VST Effect slots, mute/solo, and volume.	These are selected-track settings, not project defaults.
5	Click Apply Track Settings.	This commits the selected track controls, including VST Effect dropdowns, Enable, and Bypass.
6	Preview the track, sequence, region, or full project.	Preview renders temporary files so you can hear the result before final export.
7	Save Project.	This writes .mwproj metadata and moves attached staged AudioClip media into the saved project folder.
8	Render/export final audio or MIDI.	The render path uses saved track assignments and enabled effect chains.

Commit points at a glance

Change type	Commit button	Common mistake to avoid
Project default backend or instrument	Apply Project Defaults	Expecting project defaults to retroactively change existing tracks.
Selected-track instrument, volume, mute, solo, or VST Effect slot controls	Apply Track Settings	Changing a dropdown or checkbox and then rendering without applying track settings.
Open VST editor parameter changes	Apply Changes inside the VST editor	Closing the editor before capturing parameter changes.
Imported or recorded AudioClip media staged in temp	Save Project	Expecting Import Audio or Save / Apply recording to create a project folder before the project is saved.
Unwanted temporary previews or abandoned staging sessions	Clean Temp	Deleting workspace files manually while a project is open.

2. Core Concepts

Project

A project is the full song/session state: tracks, sequences, note data, AudioClip references, instrument assignments, VST effect-slot assignments, render settings, and user-visible metadata. Saved projects use a .mwproj file plus media folders beside it.

Track

A track is one musical or audio lane. MIDI-style tracks contain notes and instrument assignments. AudioClip tracks reference imported or recorded audio media. Both MIDI tracks and AudioClip tracks can use the two-slot VST Effect chain during offline preview/export.

Sequence

A sequence is an arrangement view or working region for a project. Sequence controls allow switching, creating blank sequences, and storing sequence thoughts/notes. Track and note edits can be scoped by the active sequence.

Staged media

Staged media is audio that belongs to the current unsaved session but has not yet been committed to a saved project folder. Imported audio and applied recording takes can both stage under workspace\temp\recordings\rec_... until Save Project commits them.

Dry source audio

Imported and recorded AudioClip files remain dry. VST effects are applied to temporary WAV files during preview/export. The original imported/recorded source media is not overwritten by effect rendering.

Offline processing

Preview, Test Effect, selected-track render, selected-sequence render, and final export use offline render paths. Live effect monitoring is separate and optional, and recorded clips remain dry even when monitor-only live effects are used.

3. Main Window Reference

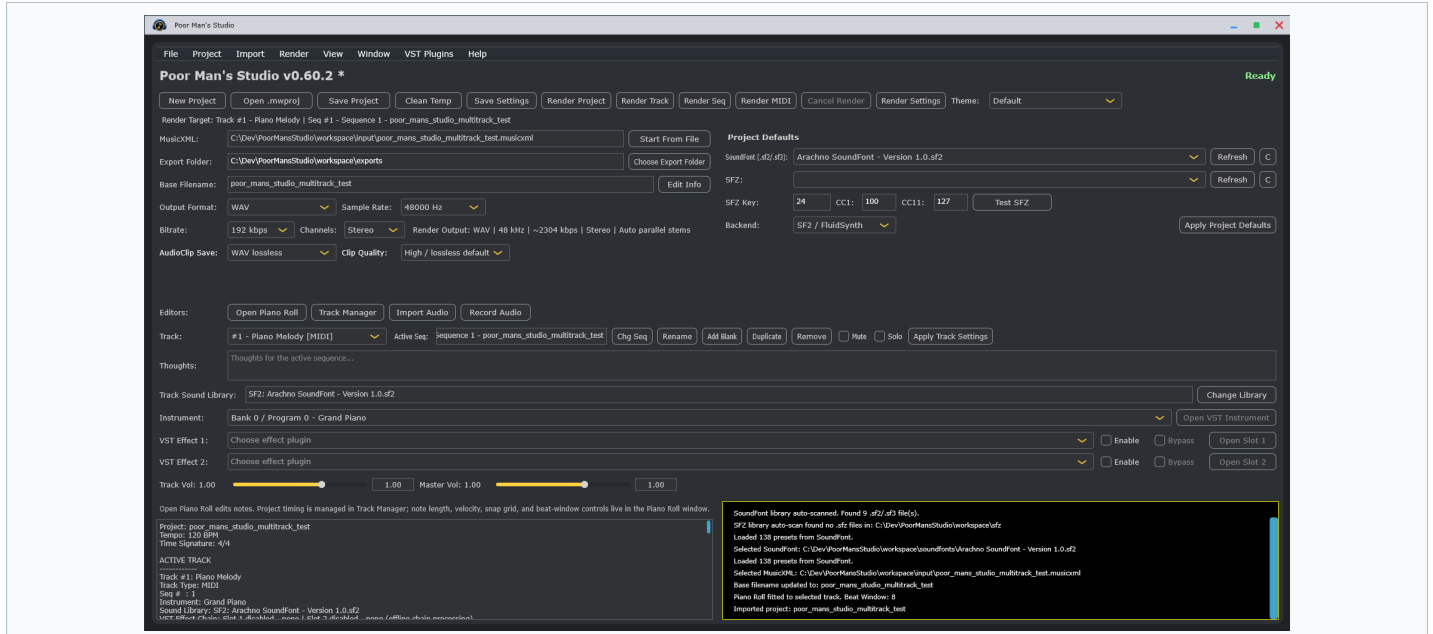


Figure 2. Main window overview with project controls, selected-track controls, two-slot VST Effect chain, preview/render controls, track summary, and log.

The main window is organized into project controls, project defaults, selected-track controls, preview/render controls, utility buttons, the track summary, and the log. The detailed button reference below is intentionally table-based so it remains useful even before final screenshots are captured.

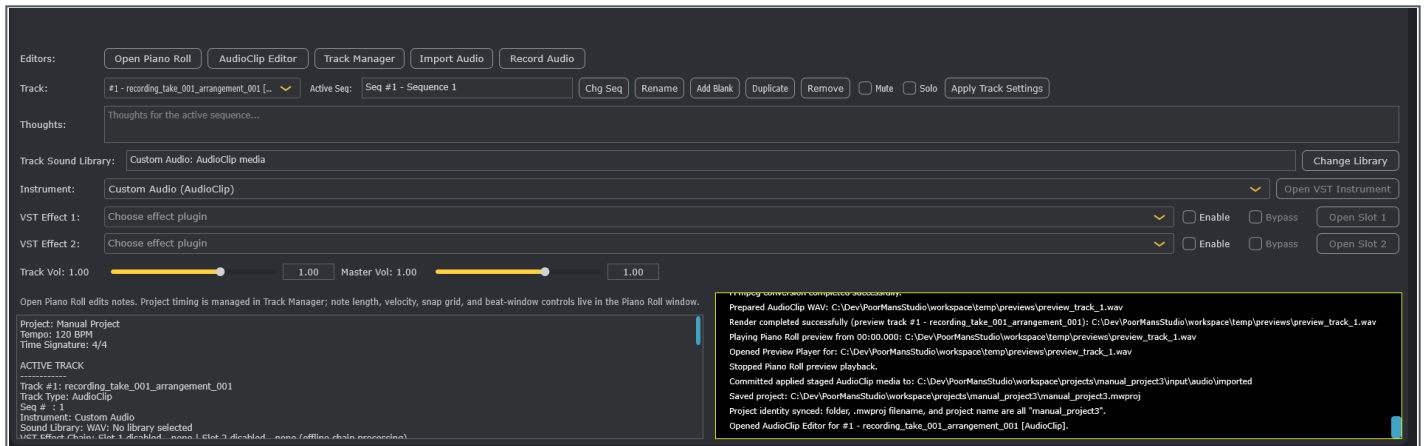
Project and file controls

Control	Purpose	Best practice
Start From File	Create a project from MusicXML, MXL, MIDI, audio, or an existing .mwproj file.	Save or intentionally discard the current project before replacing it.
Open .mwproj	Open an existing saved Poor Man's Studio project.	Open the .mwproj from inside the saved project folder so relative media paths resolve.
Save Project	Save metadata and commit attached staged AudioClip media.	Use this after importing/recording audio if you want to keep the media with the project.
Base Name	Sets the base filename for rendered output.	Use a clean song or cue name; avoid characters that are awkward in file paths.
Output Format	Chooses WAV, FLAC, MP3, OGG, or another available format.	Use WAV for high-quality intermediates and MP3/OGG for smaller sharing copies.
Export Folder	Chooses where final renders are written.	Defaulting to workspace\exports keeps rendered files away from project source media.

Project Defaults controls

Control	Purpose	Notes
Backend	Choose the default engine for future MIDI tracks: SF2/SF3, SFZ, or VST3 Plugin.	Existing tracks do not change until their own track settings are changed.
SoundFont	Choose a SoundFont or SF3 file/preset list.	Use Refresh/scan workflows when the preset list is stale.
SFZ	Choose an SFZ file or SFZ pack.	Keep samples and includes beside the SFZ file.
VST3 Plugin	Choose a scanned VST3 instrument as the default instrument backend.	Scan plugins before choosing; unsupported effects do not appear as instruments.
Apply Project Defaults	Commits project-level defaults for future imports/new tracks.	This is not the same as Apply Track Settings.

Main Window: Rendered AudioClip Arrangement Track



Main window after Render To Track creates a new imported-style AudioClip track from a local AudioClip arrangement.

After Render To Track, the new arrangement appears as a normal AudioClip track in the main track selector.

The rendered arrangement media is generated from the local AudioClip Editor arrangement. The original source recording or imported file stays untouched.

The rendered file length follows the actual last audible placed clip, not the visible arrangement-window length, so unused empty workspace does not become dead air.

If the project is already saved, the generated media is stored under the project input/audio/imported folder. If the project is unsaved, the media is staged temporarily and migrated into the project input/audio/imported folder when Save Project or Save As completes.

Project media safety: Save Project is the commit point for staged AudioClip media. Saved projects should not keep generated arrangement tracks pointing at workspace/temp.

Selected-track controls

Control	Purpose	Commit behavior		
Track	Select the track currently being edited.	Changing the selection refreshes the track controls.		
Change Library	Choose a sample/instrument library for the selected MIDI track.	Use Apply Track Settings after choosing. When you choose scanned VST3 plugin, a full chooser dialog opens instead of a tiny follow-up popup.		
Instrument	Choose the selected track's instrument/preset/plugin.	Use Apply Track Settings to commit.		
Open VST Instrument	Open the selected track's VST3 instrument editor.	Use Apply Changes in the editor after changing plugin parameters. The custom title bar shows track number, track name, Instrument, and plugin name.		
VST Effect 1 dropdown	Assign slot 1 of the selected track's VST Effect chain.	Use Apply Track Settings after selecting.		
VST Effect 1 Enable	Turn slot 1 processing on/off for preview/export.	Use Apply Track Settings as the explicit track-level commit point.		
VST Effect 1 Bypass	Temporarily skip slot 1 while keeping assignment/state.	Use Apply Track Settings after changing.		
Open Slot 1	Open the editor for VST Effect Slot 1.	Available only after slot 1 has an assigned plugin and Enable is checked; the editor toolbar uses compact wording such as Track #1 - S1 - Reverb.		
VST Effect 2 dropdown	Assign slot 2 of the selected track's VST Effect chain.	Slot 2 processes after slot 1.		
VST Effect 2 Enable	Turn slot 2 processing on/off for preview/export.	Slot 2 can be used by itself or after slot 1.		
VST Effect 2 Bypass	Temporarily skip slot 2 while keeping assignment/state.	Bypass is different from disabling because the slot remains configured.		
Open Slot 2	Open the editor for VST Effect Slot 2.	Available only after slot 2 has an assigned plugin and Enable is checked; the custom title bar uses fuller wording such as Track: #1 - Lead Vocal	S2	Plugin: Compressor.
Track Volume	Adjust selected-track volume.	Use Apply Track Settings.		
Master Volume	Adjust overall project output volume.	Preview/render uses the saved value.		
Mute / Solo	Control selected-track participation in preview/render.	Use Apply Track Settings.		

Preview and render controls

Control	What it does	Useful example
Preview Project	Renders and plays a temporary full-project preview.	Check overall balance before export.
Render	Exports the full project using the chosen render settings.	Create a final WAV or compressed file.
Render Selected Track	Render only the selected track.	Check a vocal AudioClip effect chain by itself.
Render Selected Sequence	Render only the active selected sequence.	Export an alternate arrangement or section.

Control	What it does	Useful example
Export MIDI	Write MIDI data for external use.	Move note data into another sequencer.
Cancel Render	Request cancellation of a running render.	Stop a long render after noticing a wrong setting.
Preview Latest	Play the most recent rendered WAV where available.	Quickly audition the latest export.
Render Settings	Open options for stem retention and output cleanup.	Keep stems for mixing or delete temporary stem files automatically.

Status, track summary, and log

The log is the authoritative place for detailed status: plugin scan results, unsupported plugin reasons, import results, staging paths, preview paths, render commands, VST effect-chain messages, warnings, and errors. The main window intentionally avoids large VST status text so the two effect-slot rows have room. The Window menu also acts as a window switcher: open VST instrument editors appear under VST Instrument, and open VST effect editors appear under VST Effect. VST instrument editor title bars use wording such as Track: #1 - Lead Piano | Instrument | Plugin: Dexed so the owning track is visible while editing.

4. Project Defaults And Track Settings

Project defaults

Project defaults are templates for future MIDI tracks. They decide what newly imported or newly created MIDI tracks should use by default. They do not automatically rewrite existing track assignments because that could destroy careful per-track choices.

Default area setting	Affects	Does not affect
Backend	Future imported/new MIDI tracks	Existing tracks until changed directly
SoundFont/SF3 preset	Future tracks using the SF2 backend	AudioClip tracks
SFZ file	Future tracks using the SFZ backend	VST3 instrument/effect settings
VST3 instrument	Future tracks using VST3 Plugin backend	VST Effect chain slots
Render base name/format	Future render/export output	Track note data

Track settings

Track settings belong to the currently selected track. They include instrument assignment, track volume, mute/solo, AudioClip behavior where applicable, and both VST Effect slots. Apply Track Settings is the clear commit point for these controls.

WARNING: Do not rely on an open VST editor window to save track-level changes. The editor Apply Changes captures plugin parameters. Apply Track Settings captures dropdown, Enable, Bypass, and track controls.

Why there are separate Apply buttons

Button	Scope	Why it exists
Apply Project Defaults	Project template for future tracks	Prevents accidental changes to existing tracks.
Apply Track Settings	Selected track controls	Makes the selected track's assignment/effect/mixer state explicit.
VST editor Apply Changes	Plugin parameter state	Captures native plugin UI state into the track or slot.
Save Project	Project file and attached media	Commits metadata and staged AudioClip media to a saved folder.

5. Project And Workspace File Layout

Recommended workspace

```
workspace\
  input\
  exports\           default render/export destination
  projects\
  soundfonts\
  fluidsynth\
  ffmpeg\
  sfz\
  vst3\
  vst_host\
  settings\
  temp\
  themes\
```

Recommended saved project folder

```
workspace\projects\Project Name\
  Project Name.mwproj
  input\
    midi\
    xml\
    audio\
      imported\
      recorded\
  output\
  renders\
```

Media storage rules

Media type	Unsaved project location	Saved project location	When moved
Imported AudioClip	workspace\temp\recordings\rec_...\input\audio\imported	input\audio\imported	Save Project
Applied recording take	workspace\temp\recordings\rec_...	input\audio\recorded	Save Project
Preview files	workspace\temp or render temp folders	Not committed	Clean Temp or automatic cleanup
VST test-effect WAV output	temporary effect/test location	Not committed	Automatic or Clean Temp cleanup
Final exports	Chosen export folder	Usually workspace\exports	Render/export

NOTE: Import Audio should not create a project folder under workspace\projects until the user chooses Save Project. Discarding unsaved changes removes the active staged AudioClip session.

6. Starting Projects From Files

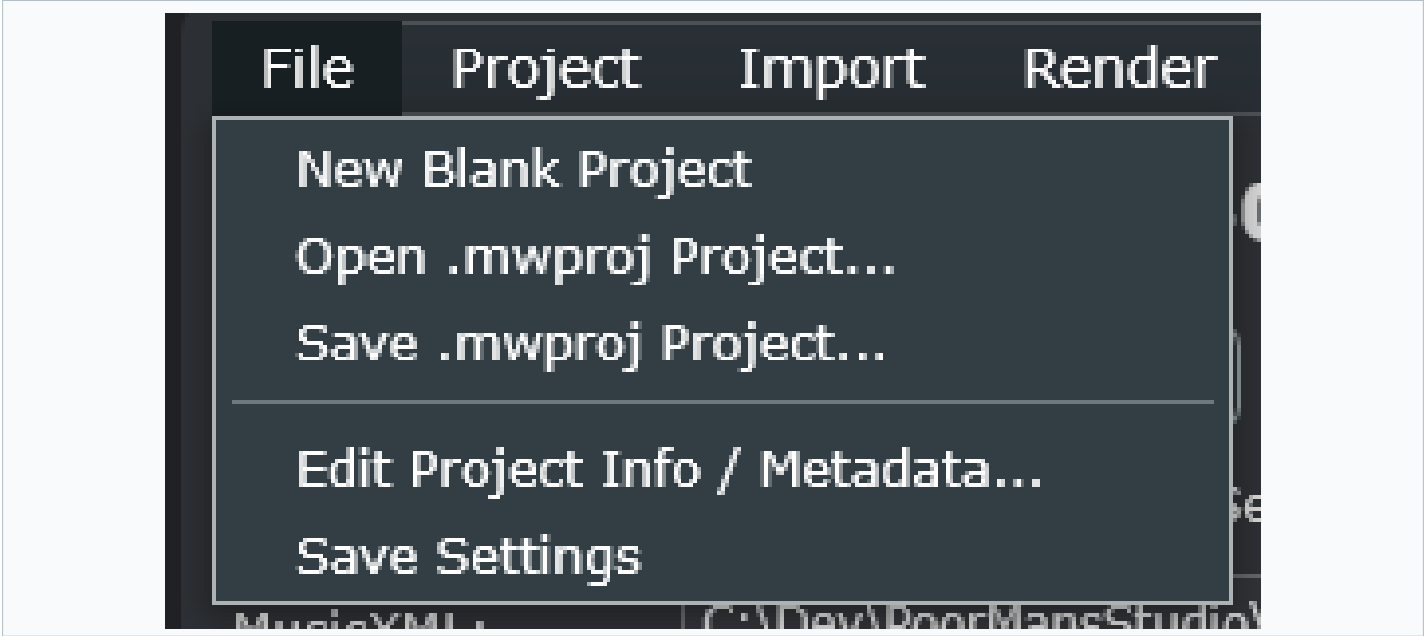


Figure 3. File menu with project open/save and app-level options.

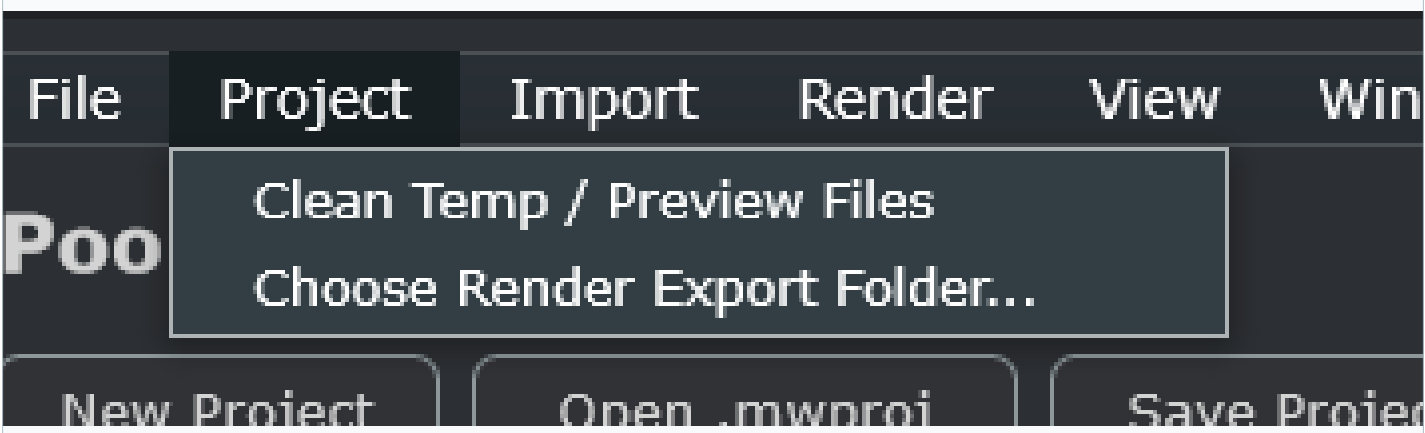


Figure 4. Project menu with project-level workflow commands.

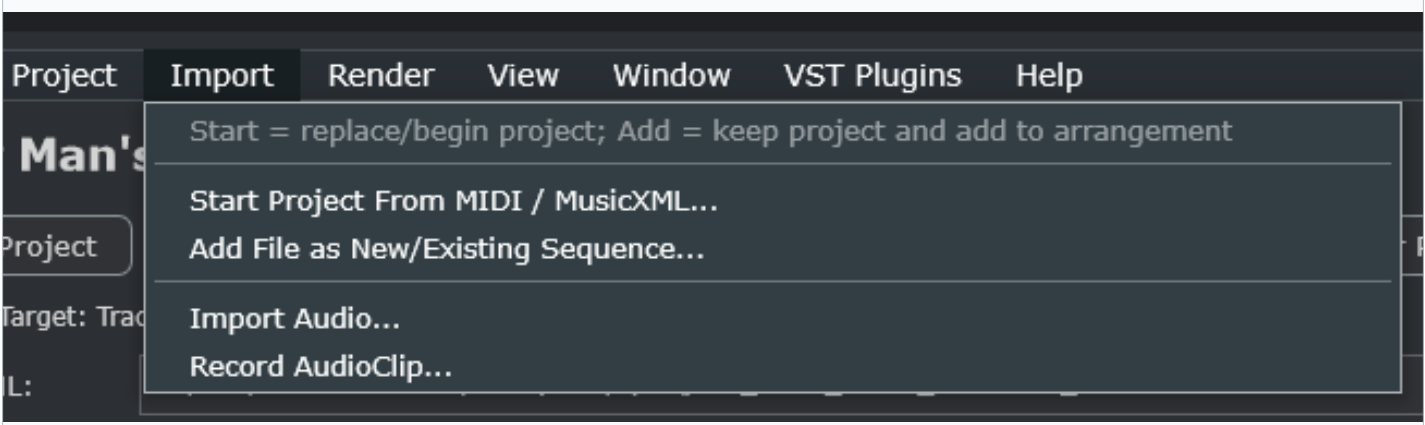


Figure 5. Import menu for bringing external sources into the current project.

Supported start points

Source	Result	Typical next step
MusicXML or MXL	Creates MIDI-style tracks and sequences from notation data.	Review instruments and use Apply Track Settings.
MIDI	Creates MIDI-style tracks from the file's note/channel data.	Choose a backend and match presets.
Audio file	Creates an AudioClip track pointing to staged or committed audio media.	Preview, add effect slots, and Save Project.
.mwproj	Reopens a saved Poor Man's Studio project.	Verify media paths and continue editing.

Unsaved-change prompts

When starting a new project, opening another project, importing a file that replaces the current project, or exiting with unsaved changes, the app prompts you to save, discard, or cancel. Discard means the active unsaved project state and active staged AudioClip session are intentionally removed.

Choice	Meaning	Staged media behavior
Save	Save the current project before continuing.	Attached staged AudioClip media is committed to the saved project.
Discard	Throw away current unsaved changes and continue.	Active staged AudioClip session is removed so it cannot attach to the wrong project.
Cancel	Do not continue the requested action.	Current project and staged session remain active.

7. Track Manager And Arrangement Workflows

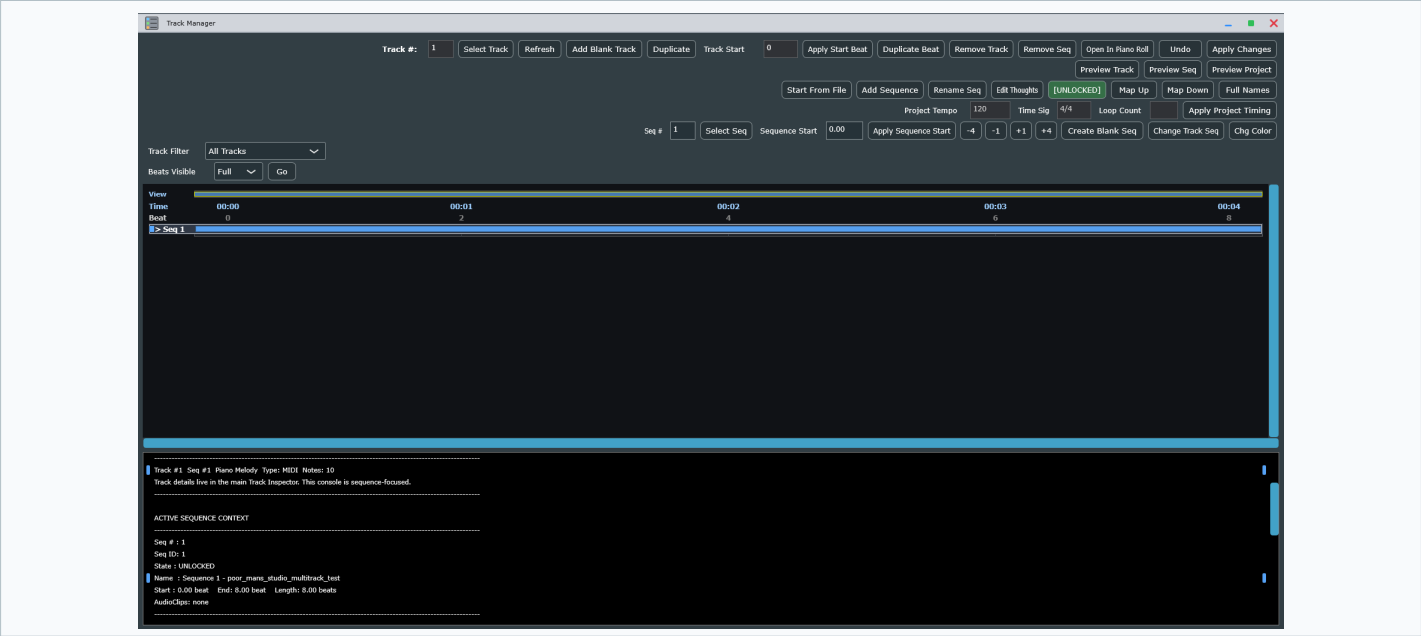


Figure 6. Track Manager view used for track organization, sequence information, and arrangement planning.

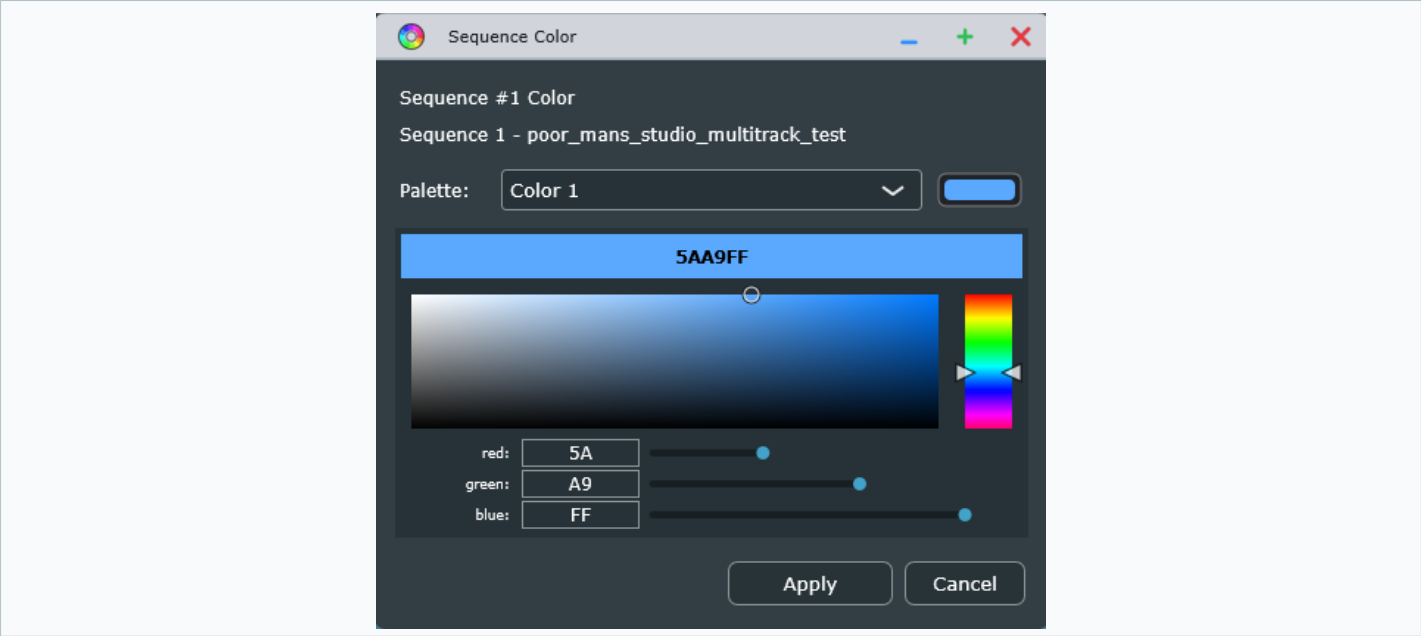


Figure 7. Sequence/color picker used when changing sequence organization or visual grouping.

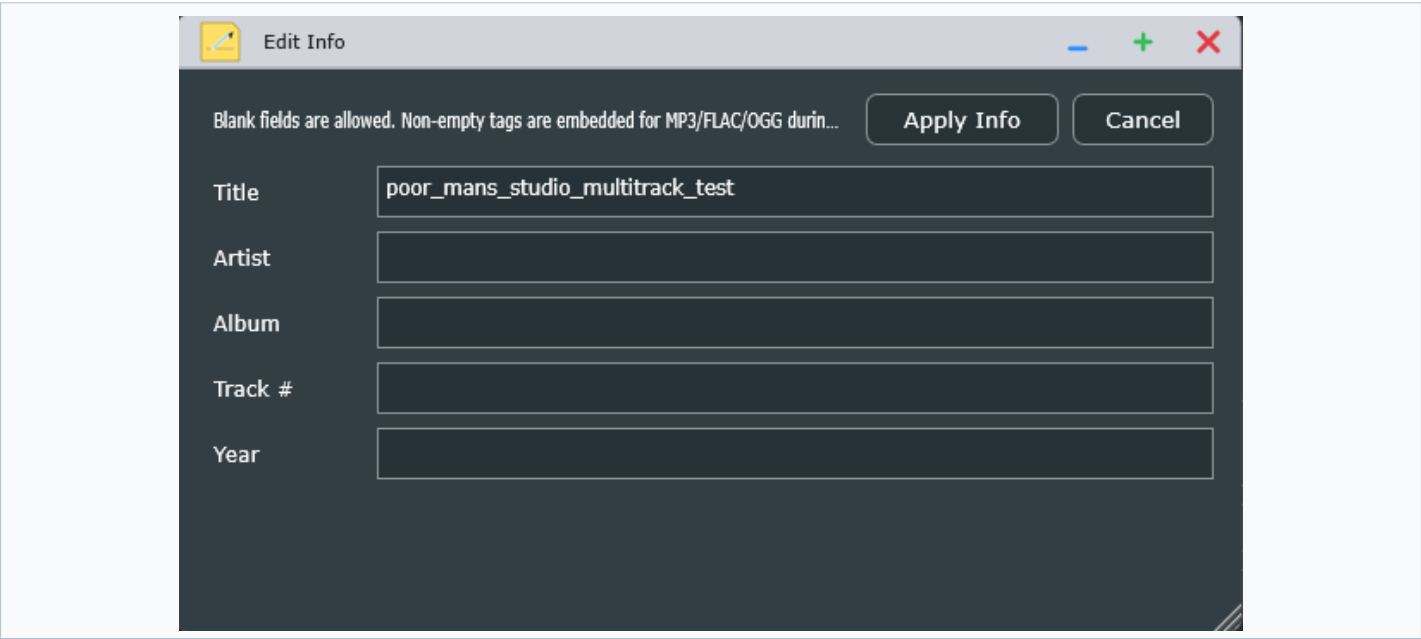


Figure 8. Edit Info dialog for project or item-level metadata.

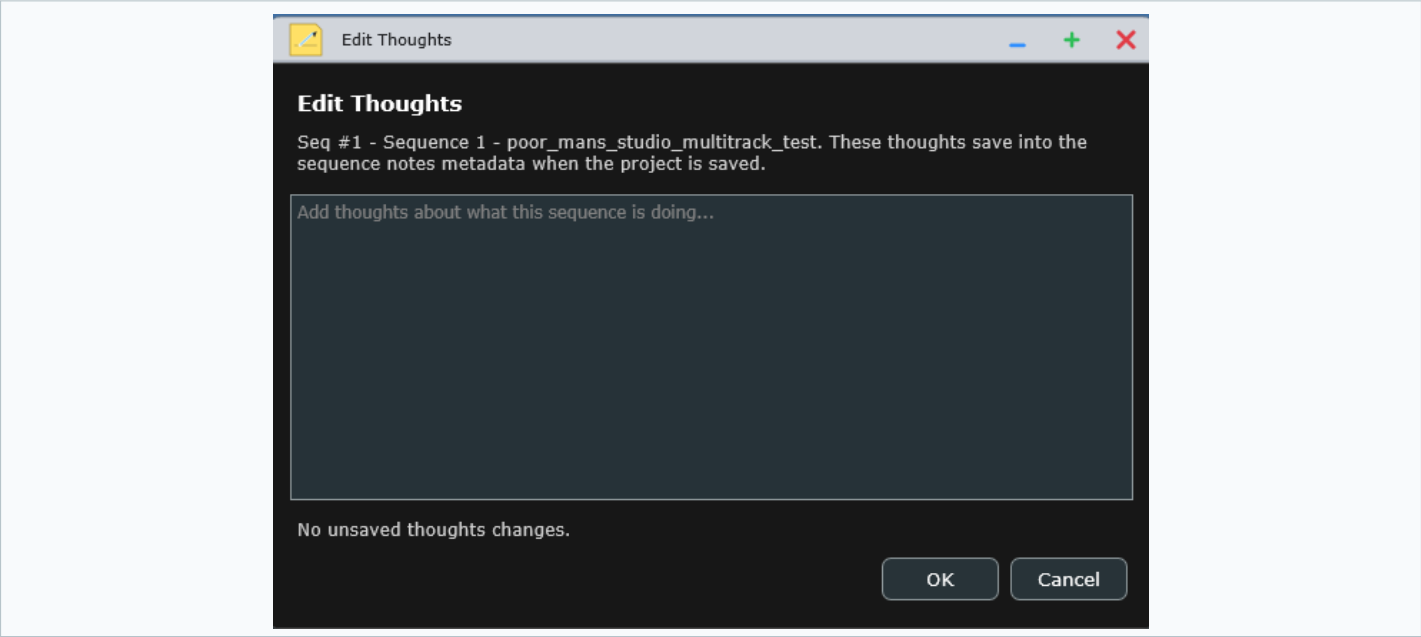


Figure 9. Edit Thoughts dialog for longer project/sequence notes.

Track Manager is the organizational center for track names, sections, sequence relationships, and notes/thoughts. It complements the main-window selected-track controls and Piano Roll note editor.

Common track management tasks

Task	Where to do it	Recommended workflow
Rename tracks	Track Manager	Use descriptive names before opening VST editors so title bars show clear track context. Instrument editors and effect editors both include track context.
Create or change sequences	Sequence controls / Track Manager	Use Chg Seq to switch or create a blank sequence.
Document arrangement ideas	Sequence Thoughts	Keep notes in the project instead of relying on external scratch files.

Task	Where to do it	Recommended workflow
Review track summaries	Main-window track summary	Check backend, library, VST instrument, effect slots, mute/solo, and volume.
Render a single track	Main render controls	Select the track, apply settings, then use Render Selected Track.

Naming advice

- Use musical names like Lead Vocal, Rhythm Guitar, Bass DI, Piano, or Strings Long instead of Track 1/2/3.
- Add role details when useful: Lead Vocal Comp, Drum Loop Imported, Room Verb Return, or Sketch Piano VST.
- Clear names are especially helpful because VST effect editor windows show the track number, slot, and plugin in the toolbar/title context.

8. Piano Roll Editing

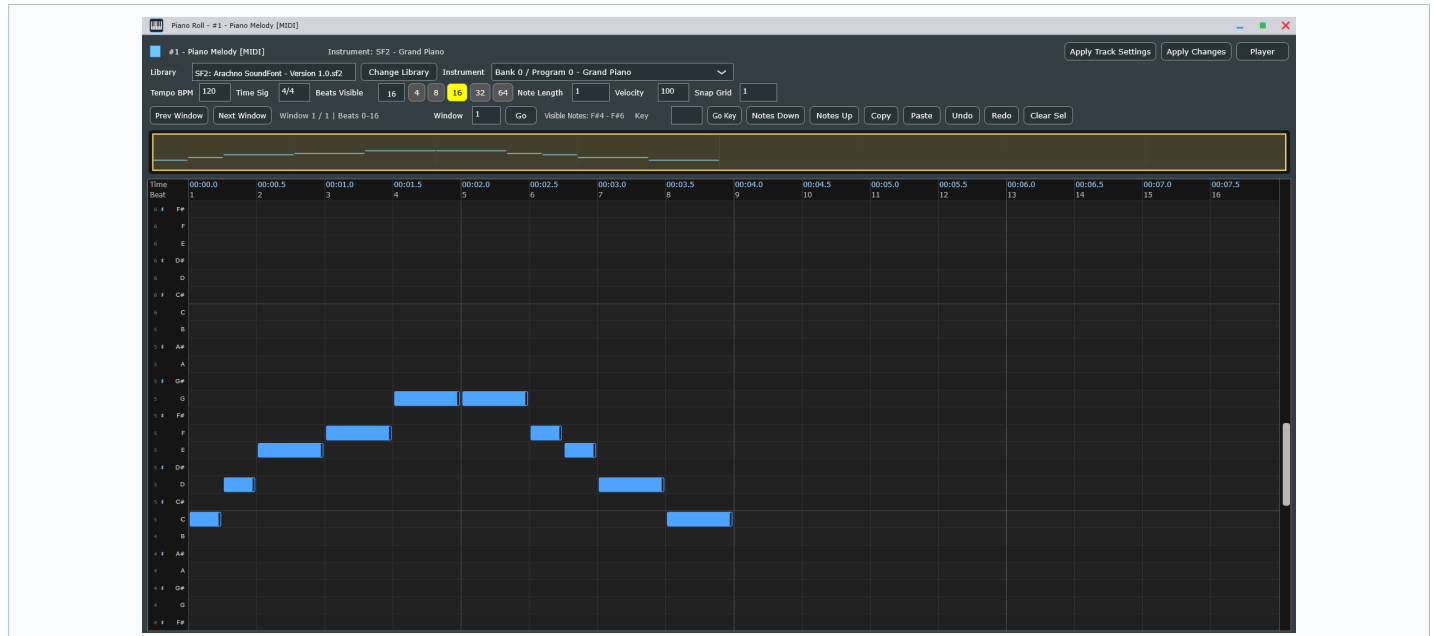


Figure 10. Piano Roll note-editing window for MIDI-style tracks.

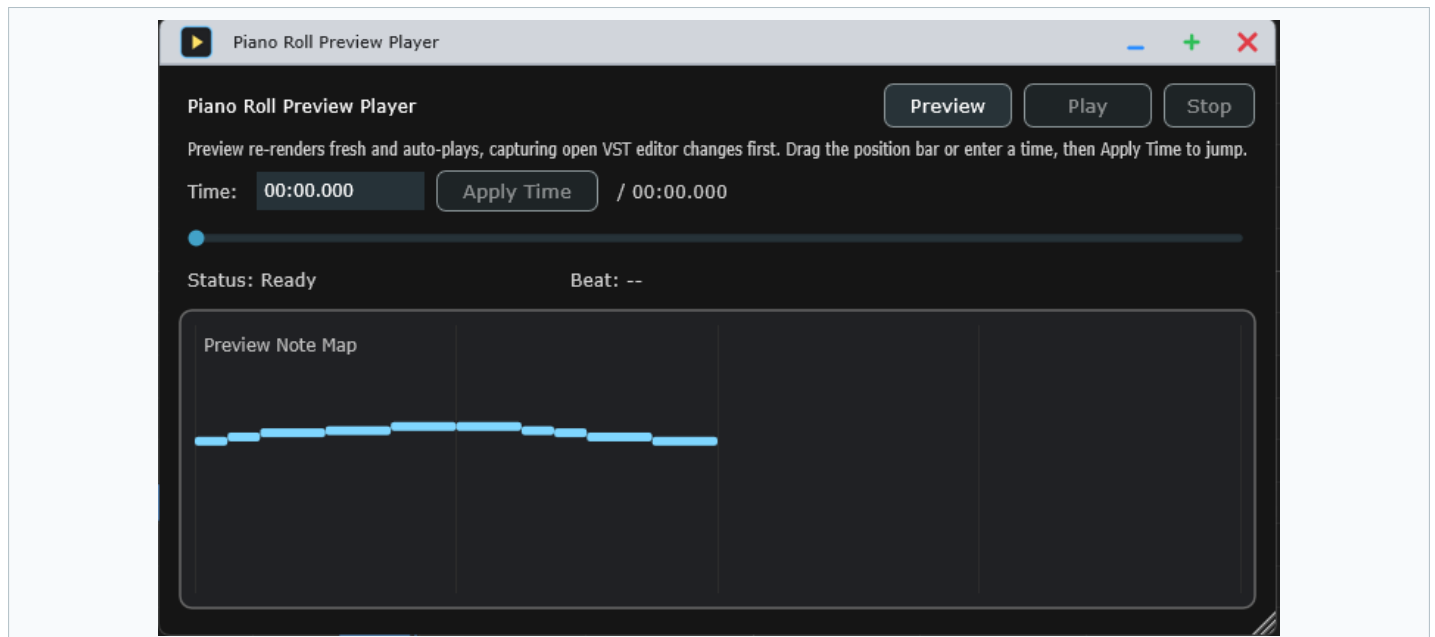


Figure 11. Piano Roll Preview Player for auditioning a rendered phrase/region.

The Piano Roll is the note editor for MIDI-style tracks. It is used for pitch, timing, velocity, note length, snap-grid, and beat-window work. AudioClip waveform editing is intentionally separate from MIDI note editing.

Piano Roll controls

Control	Purpose	Example
Open Piano Roll	Edit notes on the selected MIDI-style track.	Fix a bass note that starts late.
Beat Window	Choose how much time the Piano Roll shows at once.	Zoom to a four-beat phrase or broader section.
Page / window jump	Jump to a specific Piano Roll window number.	Move to bar/phrase areas without scrolling endlessly.
Key jump	Center a specific pitch name.	Jump to C4 or A5 while editing melody.

Control	Purpose	Example
Snap grid	Constrain editing to a musical grid.	Edit sixteenth notes cleanly.
Preview region	Render the current region temporarily.	Audition a short phrase without exporting the whole project.

Recommended edit loop

Select a track, open Piano Roll, make note edits, preview a small region, adjust track instrument/effects if needed, apply track settings, and then preview the full sequence or project. This keeps local note edits separate from track-level sound changes.

9. AudioClip Import Workflow

AudioClip import lets you bring external audio into a project as a track. Imported audio can be used dry, processed through the two-slot VST Effect chain during preview/export, or mixed with MIDI-rendered tracks.

Import behavior by project state

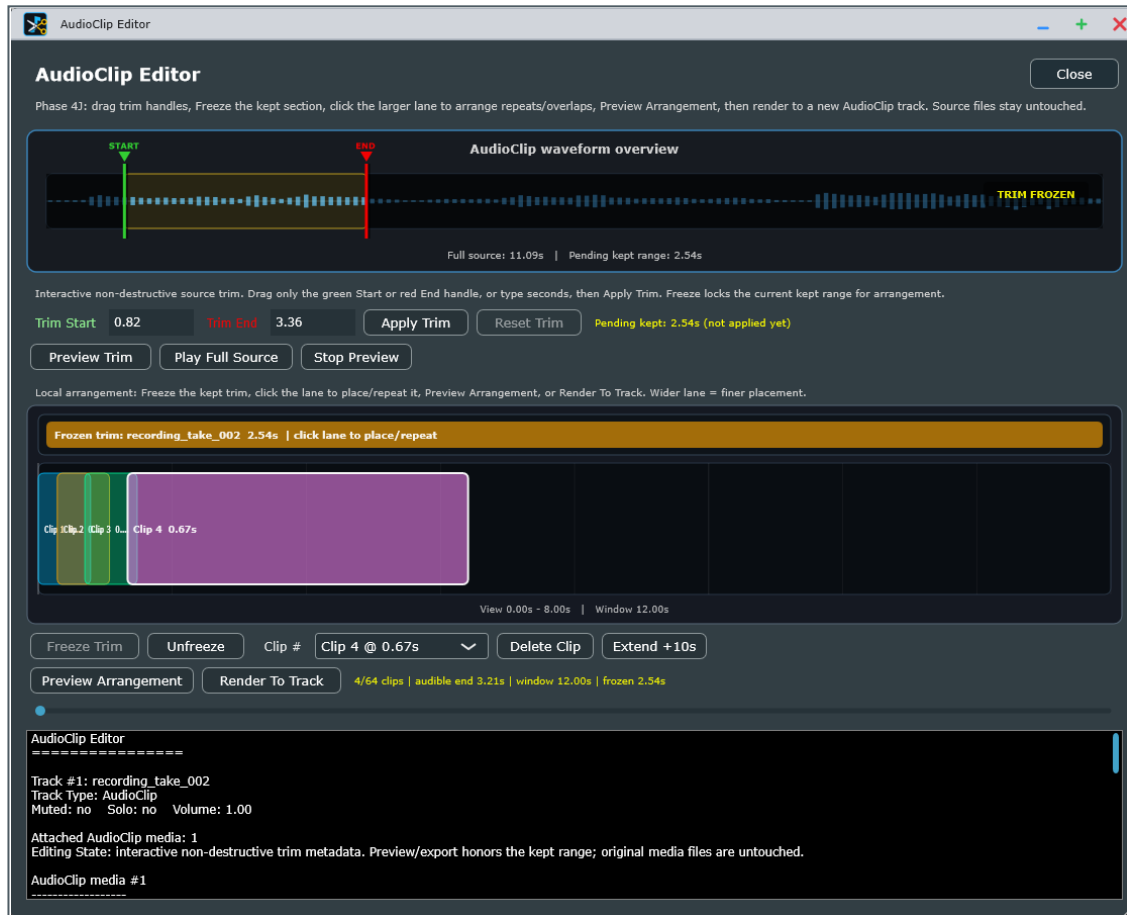
Project state	Import destination	Project folder behavior
Unsaved project	Current active staging session under workspace\temp\recordings\rec_...\input\audio\imported	No new workspace\projects folder should be created until Save Project.
Saved project	Project-relative input\audio\imported folder	Media belongs to the saved project folder.
Project discarded	Active staging session is removed	Imported media from that discarded unsaved project is intentionally deleted.

AudioClip import steps

Step	Action	Result
1	Start or open a project.	The active project/session is known.
2	Use Start From File or Import Audio to choose WAV, MP3, FLAC, or OGG.	The app creates or attaches an AudioClip track.
3	For unsaved projects, verify the log reports staging under workspace\temp\recordings\rec_....	This confirms the import is tied to the current session, not a random project folder.
4	Optional: choose VST Effect 1 and/or 2, check Enable, adjust Bypass, and click Apply Track Settings.	The imported track's offline effect chain is committed.
5	Preview or render.	Temporary processed WAVs are created if effects are active; the source stays dry.
6	Save Project when you want to keep the imported clip.	Attached staged import moves to input\audio\imported.

WARNING: If you discard an unsaved project after importing audio, the staged imported audio is removed. This is the intended safety behavior so abandoned clips do not become orphans and do not attach to the wrong project later.

AudioClip Editor: Trim, Arrange, Preview, Render



AudioClip Editor showing the source waveform, frozen trim range, local arrangement lane, repeated colored clip blocks, Preview Arrangement, and Render To Track.

Use the top waveform for non-destructive source trimming. Drag only the green Start handle or red End handle, or type trim values, then use Apply Trim to commit source-trim metadata.

Use Freeze Trim to lock the current kept range for local arrangement. Click in the larger arrangement lane to place the frozen section; click again to place another copy for loops or repeated phrases.

Placed clips are transparent colored blocks so overlaps remain visible. Use the Clip # selector to choose a placed clip and Delete Clip to remove the selected clip.

Preview Arrangement auditions the placed local arrangement without creating a new track. Render To Track creates a new imported-style AudioClip track from the arrangement.

The AudioClip Editor close warning applies only to unapplied source-trim edits. It does not delete or roll back arrangement tracks that were already created with Render To Track.

10. AudioClip Recorder Workflow

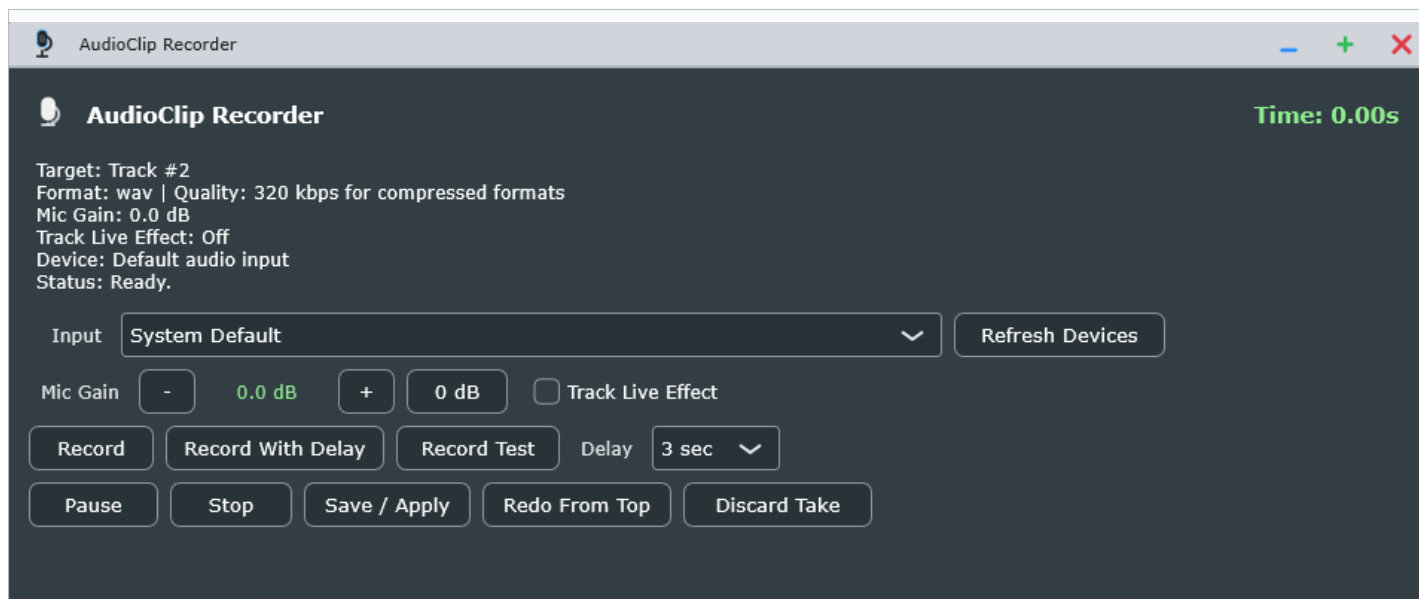


Figure 12. AudioClip Recorder window with dry-take recording, Save / Apply, redo, discard, format, gain, and live-monitor controls.

The AudioClip Recorder records dry audio into a project-session staging area, then lets you apply, redo, or discard the take. Save / Apply attaches a stopped take to the current project in memory; Save Project commits attached takes into the saved project folder.

Recorder buttons and settings

Control	Purpose	Notes
Record	Start a take into the active session staging folder.	Do not close the app mid-take if you need the file.
Stop	Stop the active take.	After stopping, choose Save / Apply, Redo, or Discard.
Save / Apply	Attach the stopped take to the current project in memory.	Does not force Save Project; the take remains staged until the project is saved.
Redo From Top	Abandon the stopped take and start over.	Keeps unwanted takes out of the project.
Discard Take	Delete or abandon the current stopped take.	Use when you know the take is not needed.
Format	Choose WAV/FLAC/MP3/OGG media format.	WAV/FLAC are lossless; MP3/OGG use the quality setting.
Quality	Choose bitrate for compressed formats.	Ignored for lossless formats.
Mic Gain	Adjust input gain before recording.	Avoid clipping before recording.
Track Live Effect	Optional monitor-only effect path.	Recorded source stays dry; offline render still uses the track effect chain.
Record Test	Record a short temporary test and play it back.	The test file is deleted automatically.

Recording commit model

Moment	File location	Project state
During recording	workspace\temp\recordings\rec_...	Not yet attached as a project clip.
After Stop	Still in staging	User chooses Save / Apply, Redo, or Discard.
After Save / Apply	Still in staging	Attached to the current project in memory.
After Save Project	input\audio\recorded	Committed to the saved project folder.
After Discard project	Staging session removed	Applied staged takes from that unsaved project are removed.

11. Two-slot VST Effect Chain

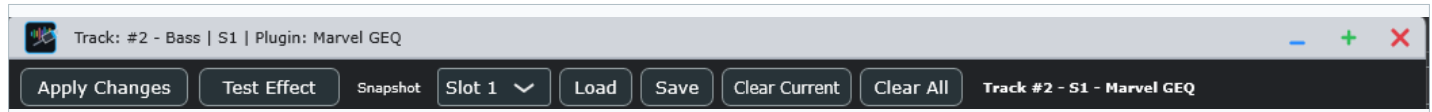


Figure 13. VST Effect editor custom title/toolbar context showing track, slot shorthand, and plugin target.

The Two-slot VST Effect chain gives each track two ordered insert slots. It works for MIDI/instrument tracks and for imported or recorded AudioClip tracks. The main-window layout stays consistent: each slot row begins with the assignment dropdown, followed by Enable, Bypass, and Open.

VST Effect 1: [dropdown] [Enable] [Bypass] [Open Slot 1]

VST Effect 2: [dropdown] [Enable] [Bypass] [Open Slot 2]

Processing order

source track

- > VST Effect 1, when assigned + enabled + not bypassed
- > VST Effect 2, when assigned + enabled + not bypassed
- > preview/export output

Slot rules

Rule	Behavior	Reason
Dropdown assignment	Chooses the Supported Effect for that slot.	Assignment must be independent from processing on/off.
Enable	Allows the slot to process during preview/export and allows its editor to open.	A slot can be assigned while disabled, but Open Slot stays unavailable until Enable is checked.
Bypass	Skips processing but preserves assignment and plugin state.	Useful for A/B testing.
Open Slot	Opens the editor for that track and slot.	Only enabled when the slot has an assigned plugin and its Enable checkbox is checked; the toolbar/title context identifies track number, slot shorthand, and plugin.
Apply Track Settings	Commits dropdown, Enable, and Bypass.	Track-level state is explicit and saved.
Apply Changes	Captures plugin parameter state from the open editor.	Plugin UI state is separate from track-level enable/assignment.

Using the same plugin in both slots

The same VST3 effect can be assigned to slot 1 and slot 2. This is allowed and useful for staged processing such as light compression followed by limiting, or two different delay/reverb settings. Each slot owns its own saved plugin state, Enable flag, and Bypass flag. During preview/export, slot 1 renders first and slot 2 processes the result.

NOTE: When the same plugin is open in both slots, use the editor toolbar/title context to verify the target. The compact toolbar uses wording like Track #1 - S1 - Reverb. The custom title bar can show fuller wording like Track: #1 - Lead Vocal | S2 | Plugin: Compressor.

Effect editor toolbar

Toolbar item	Purpose	Important detail
Compact context label	Shows the target as Track #1 - S1 - Reverb.	Useful when multiple tracks or duplicate plugins are open.
Apply Changes	Captures the current plugin state into the owning track slot.	Required after editing plugin parameters.
Test Effect	Processes the bundled short WAV through this slot.	Uses the editor's owning slot, not a different track.
Snapshot Slot 1-5	Choose a host-side snapshot slot.	Snapshots are stored outside the project under workspace\lst3\snapshots.
Load	Load a snapshot into the current editor and apply it.	Check the compact toolbar/title context first.

Toolbar item	Purpose	Important detail
Save	Save the current plugin state to the selected snapshot.	Useful for reusable favorite settings.
Clear Current	Clear the selected snapshot slot.	Asks for confirmation.
Clear All	Clear all five snapshot slots for that plugin/role.	Asks for confirmation.

Effect chain troubleshooting checklist

- Confirm the desired slot has a Supported Effect selected in the dropdown.
- Confirm Enable is checked for that slot.
- Confirm Bypass is unchecked for that slot.
- Click Apply Track Settings after changing dropdown, Enable, or Bypass.
- Open the correct slot editor and click Apply Changes after changing plugin parameters.
- Check the log for missing bundle, unsupported plugin, processing, or render errors.

12. VST3 Plugin Manager And Instrument Hosting

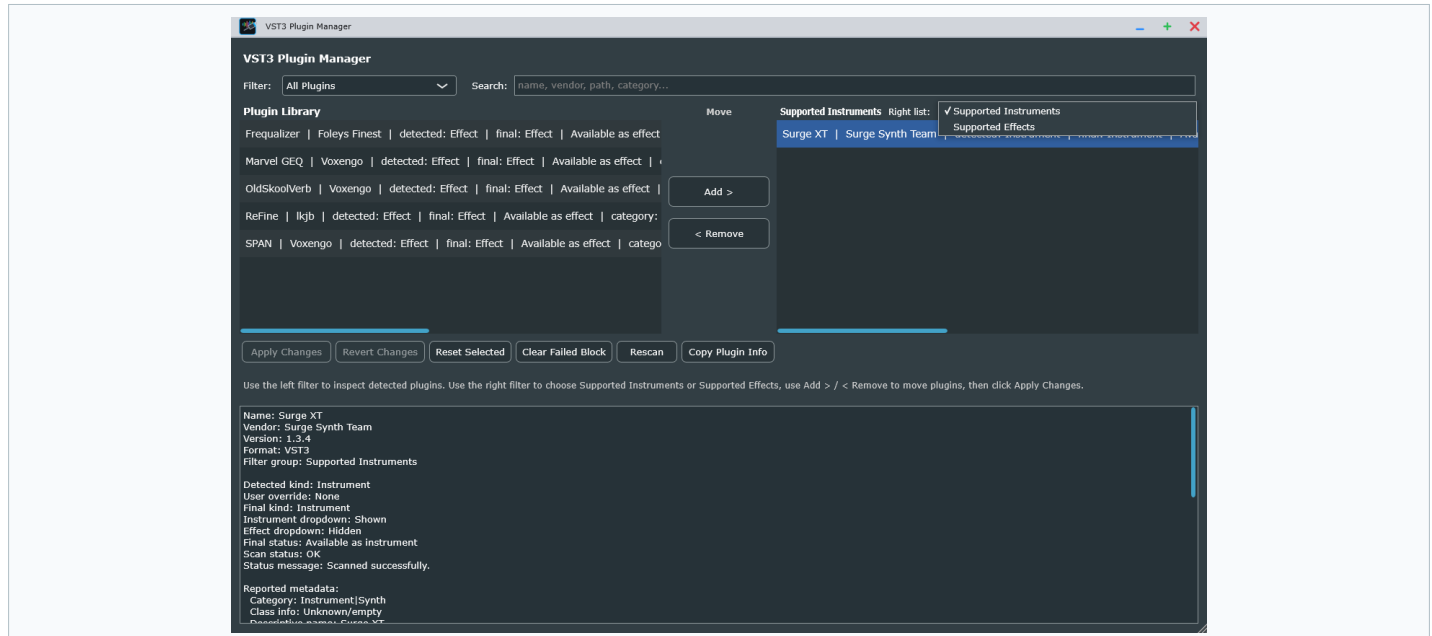


Figure 14. VST3 Plugin Manager with scanned plugin status and classification.

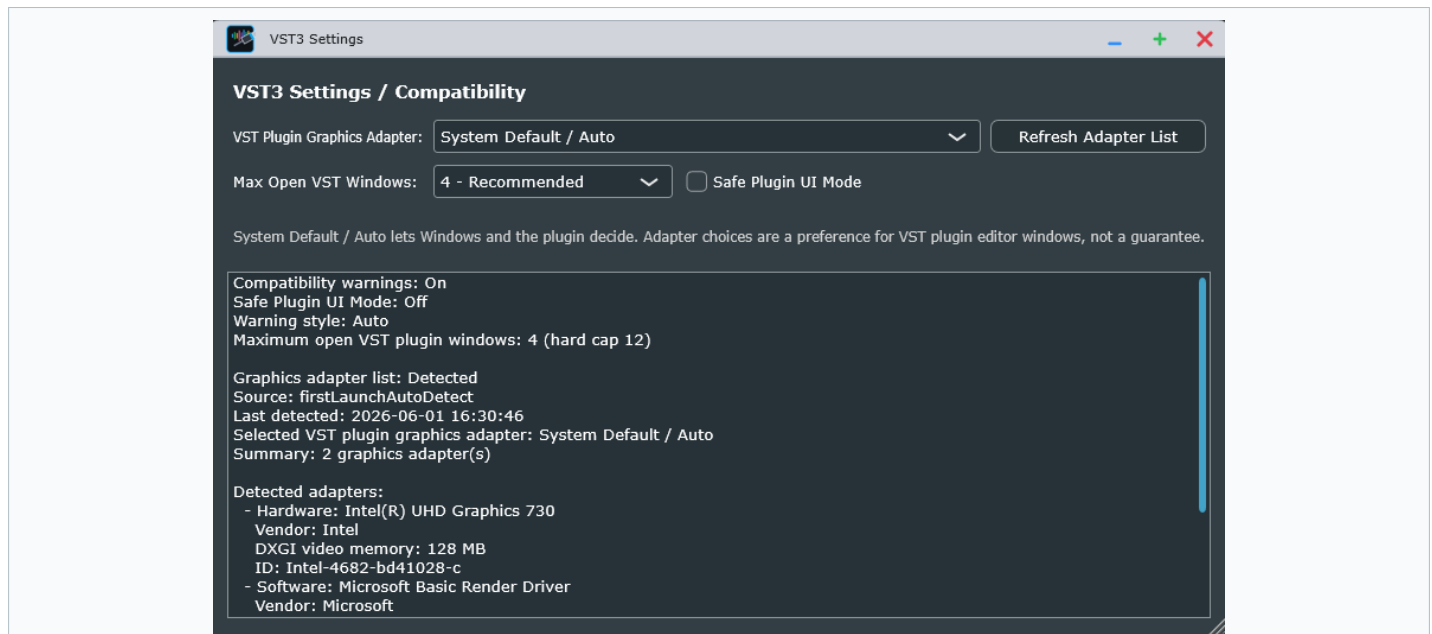


Figure 15. VST3 Settings dialog for plugin scanning and host preferences.

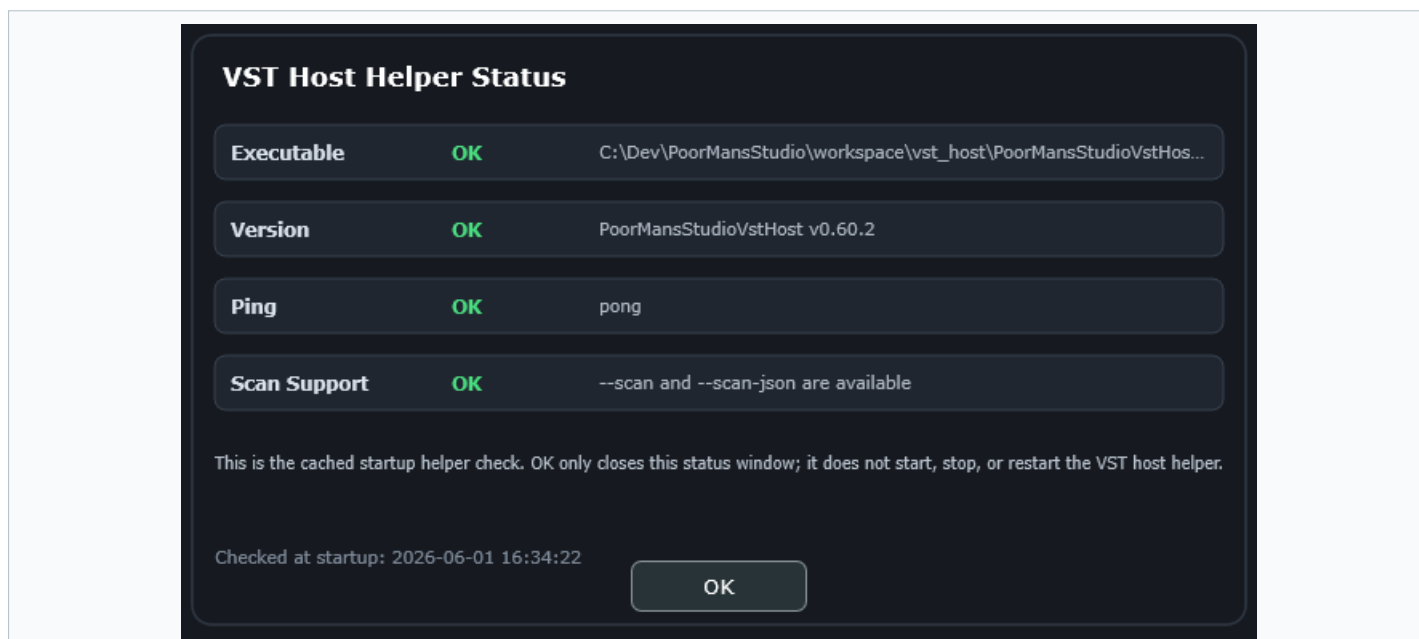


Figure 16. VST host/helper status window for helper process state and diagnostics.

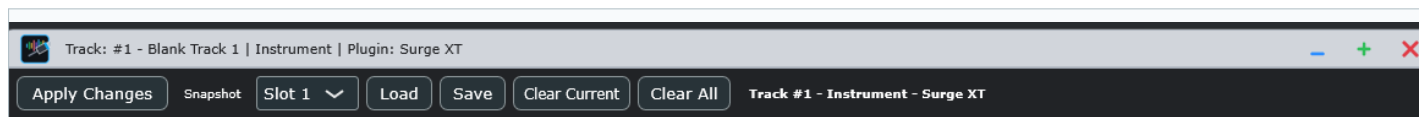


Figure 17. VST Instrument editor title/context showing track number, track name, instrument role, and plugin name.

VST3 support is experimental. VST instruments can be used as track instruments; VST effects can be used in the two-slot effect chain when classified as Supported Effects. Plugins can crash inside their own native code, so save important work before testing unfamiliar plugins.

Plugin folders

Folder	Purpose	Notes
workspace\vst3	User/test VST3 bundles bundled with the workspace.	Good place for portable testing.
C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3	Standard Windows VST3 install location.	Many installers place plugins here.
workspace\vst3\test	Runtime VST effect test WAV.	The test WAV stays as a normal runtime file, not embedded BinaryData.
workspace\vst3\snapshots	Host-side snapshot storage.	Used by Load/Save/Clear snapshot toolbar buttons.

Plugin classification

Classification	Appears where	When to use
Supported Instrument	Instrument dropdown when backend is VST3 Plugin	Use as a MIDI track instrument.
Supported Effect	VST Effect 1 and VST Effect 2 dropdowns	Use as an insert effect during offline preview/export.
Warning	May show with a warning marker/log details	Use only if you understand the risk.
Unsupported/Failed	Hidden from normal assignment controls	Review details in the Plugin Manager; rescan after fixing.

Safe VST testing workflow

Step	Action	Reason
1	Save the project before scanning or opening unknown plugins.	A crashing plugin can take down the app.

Step	Action	Reason
2	Scan VST3 Plugins.	Builds the known plugin catalog.
3	Check status/classification in the Plugin Manager.	Avoid assigning a plugin in the wrong role.
4	Assign one plugin to one test track first.	Limits troubleshooting scope.
5	Open the editor and use Apply Changes.	Captures parameter state.
6	Use Test Effect or short preview before full render.	Finds failures quickly.

13. SoundFont, SF3, And SFZ Workflows

SoundFont/SF3

SoundFont and SF3 instruments are rendered through FluidSynth. Choose a file, refresh/inspect presets when needed, select a preset, and apply the project or track setting. General MIDI matching can help imported MIDI tracks choose sensible presets.

Task	Control/path	Advice
Choose library	SoundFont selector	Keep stable libraries under workspace\soundfonts.
Choose preset	Preset/instrument dropdown	Use General MIDI names where possible.
Render	FluidSynth path/settings	Check the log if rendering fails.

SFZ

SFZ instruments are rendered through sfizz. Keep the .sfz file, sample folders, and included files together. Poor Man's Studio validates sample references so missing files can be caught before render.

Issue	Likely cause	Fix
SFZ render silent or failed	Missing sample files or wrong relative paths	Keep samples beside the SFZ or adjust paths.
Key switch not working	Wrong key switch note	Set the optional key switch value for the SFZ.
Expression/modulation missing	CC1/CC11 not configured	Set optional CC1/CC11 values where the instrument expects them.

14. Preview, Render, Export, And Stems

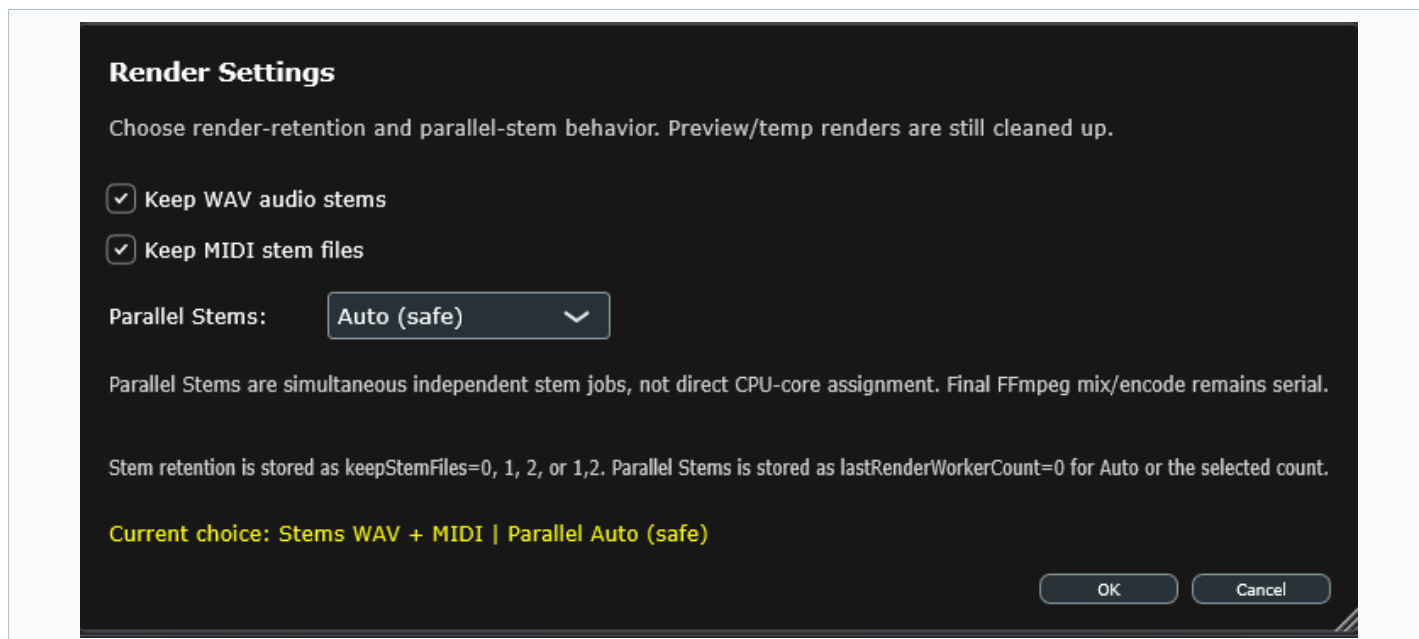


Figure 18. Render Settings dialog for output cleanup and stem retention options.

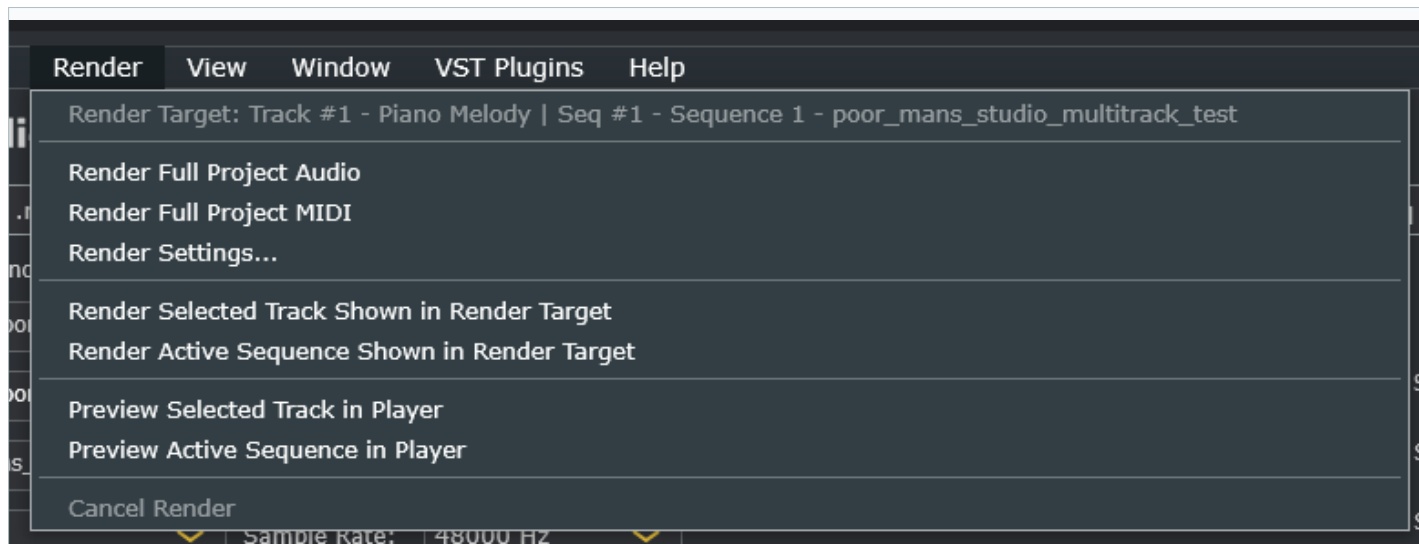


Figure 19. Render menu with preview, export, and render-related actions.

Preview and render paths create temporary or final audio by rendering tracks, applying enabled effect chains, and mixing the result. Selected-track and selected-sequence render are useful for debugging before a full export.

Render settings

Setting	Purpose	Recommended use
Sample Rate	Sets output sample rate.	48 kHz is a practical default; use project/client requirements when known.
Channels	Mono or stereo output.	Use stereo for most music renders.
Bitrate	Compressed output quality.	Higher values improve MP3/OGG quality at larger file size.
Keep WAV stems	Preserve per-track audio stems.	Use when you want to inspect or mix stems elsewhere.
Keep MIDI stems	Preserve per-track MIDI stem files.	Use for debugging instrument/render problems.

Setting	Purpose	Recommended use
Cleanup rendered output	Remove temporary render sidecars when appropriate.	Use to keep workspace tidy after exports.

How effects are applied during render

Track type	First stage	Effect stage	Output stage
MIDI + SF2/SF3	Render MIDI through FluidSynth	Process enabled slot 1 then slot 2	Mix/export
MIDI + SFZ	Render MIDI through sfizz	Process enabled slot 1 then slot 2	Mix/export
MIDI + VST3 instrument	Render MIDI through VST3 instrument	Process enabled slot 1 then slot 2	Mix/export
Imported AudioClip	Read staged/committed source audio	Create temporary processed WAV through slot chain	Mix/export; source stays dry
Recorded AudioClip	Read staged/committed dry take	Create temporary processed WAV through slot chain	Mix/export; take stays dry

15. Clean Temp And Media Safety

Clean Temp is the safe way to remove temporary render files, preview files, test-effect output, and abandoned staged AudioClip media. It should not remove committed media inside saved project folders.

What Clean Temp can remove

Item	Removed by Clean Temp	Notes
Preview files	Yes	Temporary by design.
Test Effect output	Yes	The source test WAV remains a runtime file.
Abandoned staging sessions	Yes, after confirmation	Includes staged imported and recorded AudioClip media not committed to a saved project.
Committed input\audio\imported	No	Saved project media is not temp.
Committed input\audio\recorded	No	Saved project media is not temp.
Final exports	No	Exports are user output, not temp.

Discard safety

New Project, Open Project, Start From File, and Exit discard paths should remove the active staging session before moving on. This prevents staged AudioClip imports or recording takes from being left behind or accidentally reused by the wrong project/session.

16. Settings, Themes, And Helper Bubbles

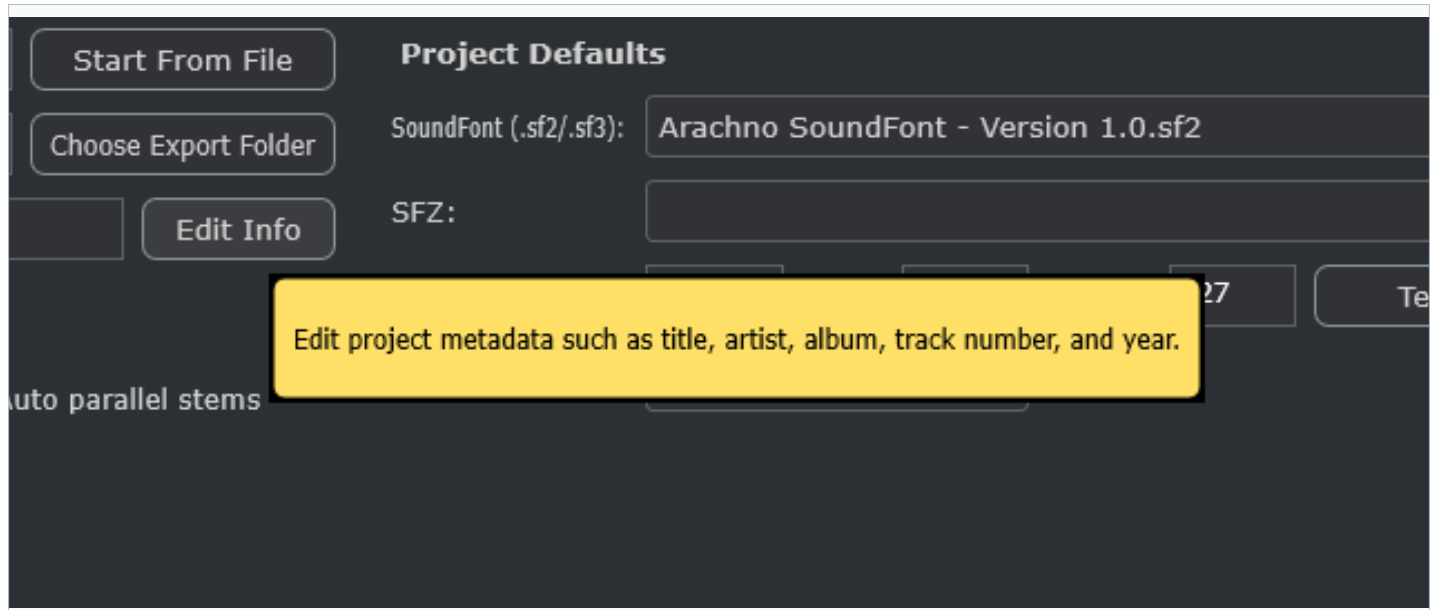


Figure 20. Helper bubble example showing delayed contextual help text.

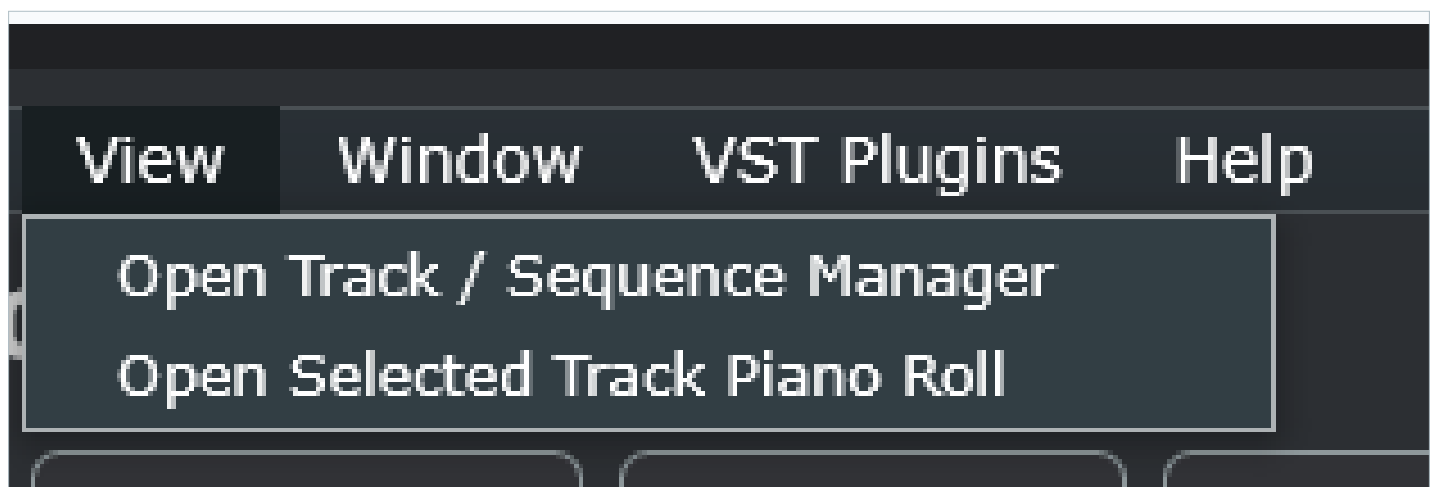


Figure 21. View menu for UI visibility and related options.

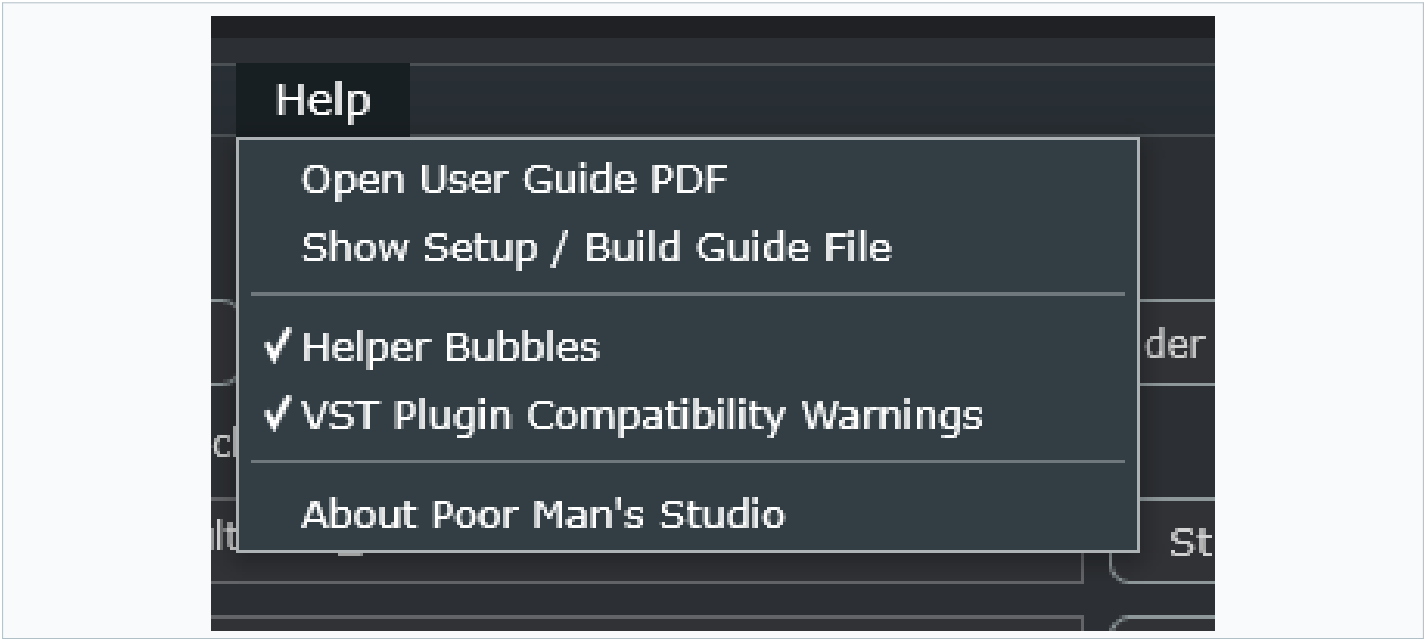


Figure 22. Help menu with guide/helper-bubble access and support commands.

Helper bubbles

Helper bubbles show explanatory text when hovering on controls for about two seconds. They are useful while learning the app and can be toggled from the Help menu.

Themes

Themes affect visual styling only. Theme changes do not alter project audio data, plugin assignments, render settings, or media paths.

Preferences

Preference area	Purpose	Notes
VST graphics adapter	Stores compact numeric preferred adapter selection.	The full adapter cache list is stored separately under workspace\settings\vst_graphics_adapters.txt.
Window/theme preferences	Control UI appearance.	Does not affect render output.
Paths	Remember common tool/library locations.	Keep external tools in predictable workspace folders when possible.

17. Example Workflows

Example A - MIDI sketch with SoundFont output

Step	Action
1	Put a SoundFont/SF3 file under workspace\soundfonts.
2	Choose Backend = SF2/SF3 and select the SoundFont preset.
3	Click Apply Project Defaults.
4	Start From File and import a MIDI or MusicXML file.
5	Review each track and adjust presets where needed.
6	Click Apply Track Settings after selected-track changes.
7	Preview Project, then Render final WAV or compressed audio.

Example B - Imported vocal with EQ and compressor

Step	Action
1	Start or open a project and import the vocal audio file.
2	Select the imported AudioClip track.
3	In VST Effect 1, choose an EQ plugin; check Enable; leave Bypass unchecked.
4	In VST Effect 2, choose a compressor plugin; check Enable; leave Bypass unchecked.
5	Click Apply Track Settings.
6	Open Slot 1, adjust EQ, click Apply Changes.
7	Open Slot 2, adjust compression, click Apply Changes.
8	Render Selected Track to verify the effect chain.
9	Save Project to commit the imported AudioClip if the project was unsaved.

Example C - Same plugin in both effect slots

Step	Action
1	Assign the same plugin to VST Effect 1 and VST Effect 2.
2	Enable both slots and click Apply Track Settings.
3	Open Slot 1 and set the first-stage processing; click Apply Changes.
4	Open Slot 2 and set the second-stage processing; click Apply Changes.
5	Check the compact toolbar/title before editing so you know which track and slot are being changed.
6	Preview/export. Slot 1 renders first; slot 2 processes slot 1's output.

Example D - Unsaved project with imported audio

Step	Action
1	Create a new project but do not save it yet.
2	Import an audio file.
3	Confirm the log reports a staging path under workspace\temp\recordings\rec_....
4	Preview and adjust effects as needed.
5	Choose Save Project to keep the import, or Discard to remove the active staging session.

Example E - Record a dry take and render with effects

Step	Action
1	Select or create the target AudioClip track.
2	Record a take and stop.
3	Click Save / Apply to attach the take to the project in memory.
4	Assign VST Effect slots on the track, check Enable, and click Apply Track Settings.
5	Open slot editors as needed and click Apply Changes after parameter edits.
6	Preview/render. The dry take is processed only through temporary render files.
7	Save Project to commit the take into input\audio\recorded.

18. Troubleshooting

VST Effect chain issues

Symptom	Likely cause	Fix
Enable checkbox appears to turn off again	Control state was refreshed before the click was committed in older builds.	Use this build or later; click Enable, then Apply Track Settings if needed.
Effect selected but not audible	Enable is off, Bypass is on, or Apply Track Settings was not clicked.	Check slot controls and apply track settings.
Plugin parameter edits do not render	Apply Changes was not clicked in the editor.	Open the correct slot and apply changes.
Wrong slot edited	Same plugin used in both slots or multiple windows open.	Read the editor toolbar/title context, for example Track #1 - S1 - Reverb.
Effect missing from dropdown	Plugin is not classified as Supported Effect.	Review Plugin Manager status and rescan or classify appropriately.
Render fails on effect	Plugin failed to load or crashed during offline processing.	Check log details, bypass/remove the plugin, or mark it unsupported.

AudioClip staging issues

Symptom	Likely cause	Fix
Imported audio disappeared after discard	Discard intentionally removed the active unsaved staging session.	Save Project before discard if you want to keep the clip.
Unexpected folder in workspace\projects	Import path should not create project folders before Save Project.	Check the log and use the current build; report the exact steps if it reappears.
Clip missing after moving project	Only .mwproj was moved, not the full project folder.	Move/share the entire saved project folder.
Staging folder still contains old media	Abandoned sessions were not cleaned.	Use Clean Temp after confirming no wanted unsaved media remains.

Render and external tool issues

Symptom	Likely cause	Fix
MP3/FLAC/OGG export fails	FFmpeg path missing or invalid.	Configure FFmpeg and check the log command.
SF2 render fails	FluidSynth path/library issue.	Verify FluidSynth executable and SoundFont path.
SFZ render fails	sfizz path or sample references missing.	Check sfizz setup and SFZ sample includes.
Preview works but final render differs	Different selected track/sequence/render settings.	Apply settings and render a selected track/sequence to isolate.

19. Button And Menu Index

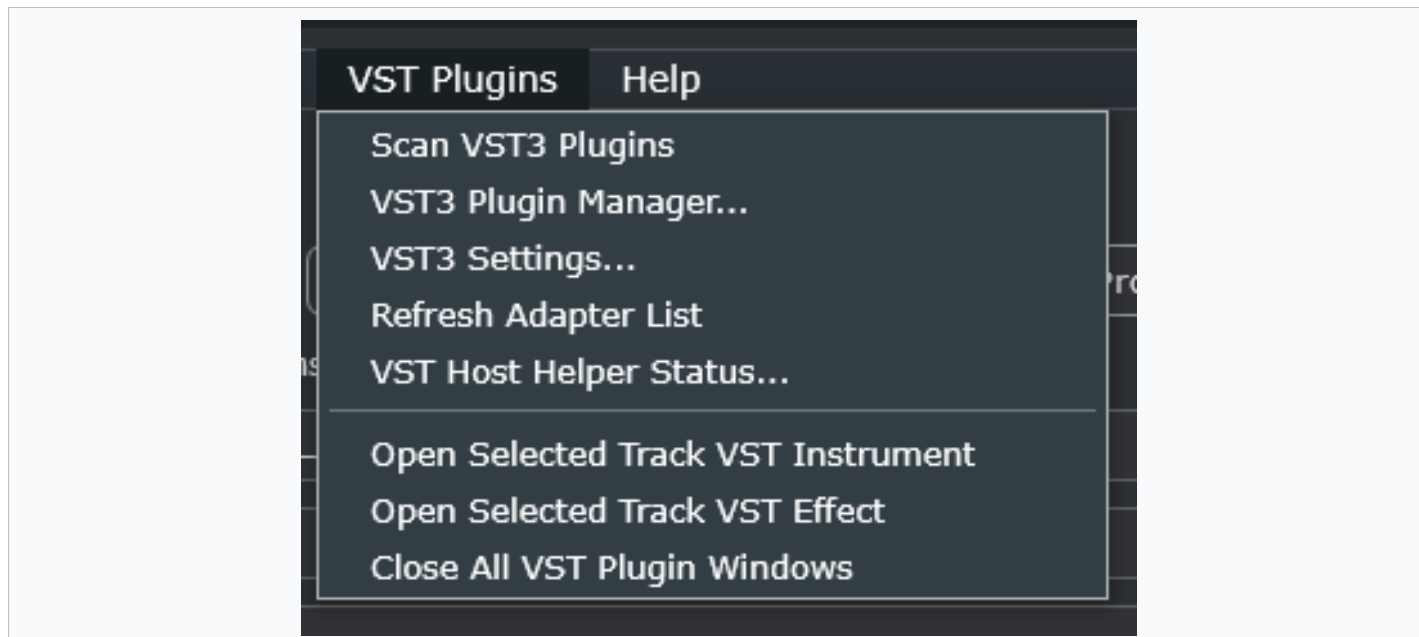


Figure 23. VST Plugins menu for scanning, plugin manager access, and VST-related workflows.

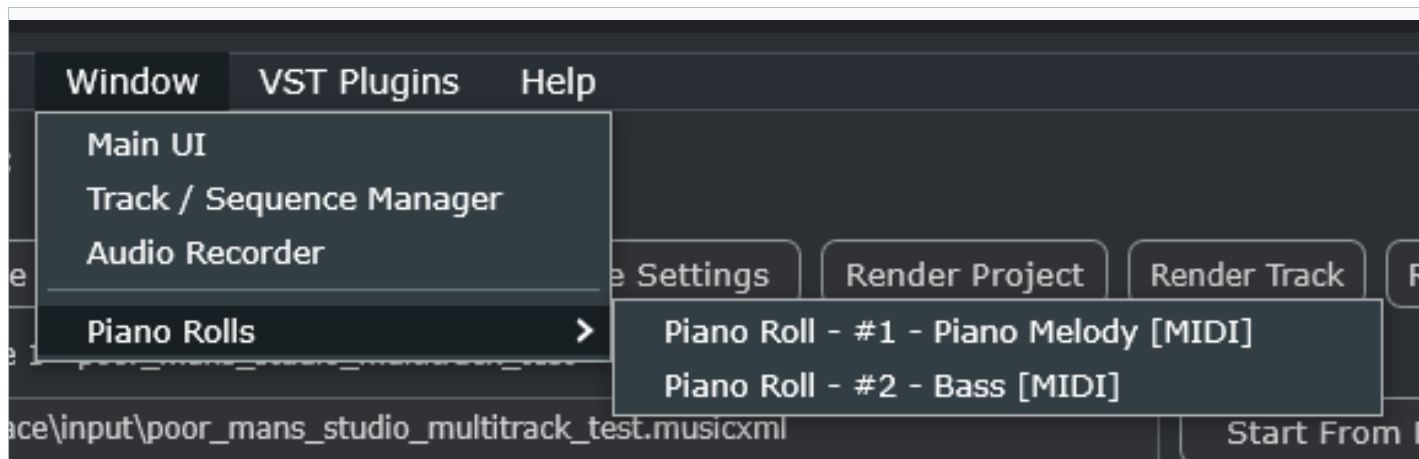


Figure 24. Window menu with Piano Roll, VST Instrument, and VST Effect side submenus for bringing open editors forward.

This index is broad so button and menu names can be found quickly. Linked entries jump to the most relevant section in this guide.

Button/Menu	Where	Summary
Apply Changes	VST editor toolbar	Capture plugin UI state for the editor's owning track/slot.
Apply Project Defaults	Main window Project Defaults	Commit backend/instrument defaults for future tracks.
Apply Track Settings	Main window Track Controls	Commit selected-track instrument, mixer, and VST effect-slot controls.
Bypass	VST Effect slot rows	Skip a configured effect slot without clearing it.
Cancel Render	Render controls	Request render cancellation.
Change Library	Track Controls	Pick the selected track's library/source.
Clean Temp	Utility/menu	Remove temp files and abandoned staged media after confirmation.
Clear All	VST editor snapshots	Clear all host snapshots for the plugin/role.
Clear Current	VST editor snapshots	Clear the selected host snapshot slot.

Button/Menu	Where	Summary
Enable	VST Effect slot rows	Allow that slot to process during preview/export.
Export MIDI	Render/export controls	Export MIDI data.
Helper Bubbles	Help menu	Toggle delayed tooltips/help bubbles.
Import Audio	Start From File/import workflow	Create an AudioClip track from audio media.
Load	VST editor snapshots	Load selected snapshot into the current editor.
Mute	Track Controls	Mute selected track.
Open Slot 1	VST Effect 1 row	Open effect slot 1 editor after a plugin is assigned and Enable is checked.
Open Slot 2	VST Effect 2 row	Open effect slot 2 editor after a plugin is assigned and Enable is checked.
Open VST Instrument	Track Controls	Open selected track's VST instrument editor.
Window > VST Instrument	Window menu	Side submenu listing open VST instrument editors; choose an item to bring that editor to the front.
Window > VST Effect	Window menu	Side submenu listing open VST effect editors by track/slot/plugin; choose an item to bring that editor to the front.
Preview Project	Render controls	Temporary full-project preview.
Record Test	AudioClip Recorder	Record/play/delete a short test.
Render	Render controls	Final project export.
Render Selected Sequence	Render controls	Export active sequence only.
Render Selected Track	Render controls	Export selected track only.
Save	VST editor snapshots	Save current plugin state as a host snapshot.
Save / Apply	AudioClip Recorder	Attach stopped take to current project in memory.
Save Project	Project controls	Write .mwproj and commit attached staged AudioClip media.
Scan VST3 Plugins	VST Plugins menu	Build/update plugin catalog.
Solo	Track Controls	Solo selected track.
Start From File	Project controls	Create/replace project from a supported file.
Test Effect	VST editor toolbar	Process bundled short WAV through the editor's owning slot.
VST Plugins Manager	VST Plugins menu	Review plugin status/classification.

20. Dialog And Window Reference

This section summarizes the major secondary windows and dialogs. It is a text/table substitute for screenshots and should remain useful even after final screenshots are added later.

VST3 Plugin Manager

Area	Purpose	Workflow notes
Plugin catalog	Shows scanned VST3 bundles and their status/classification.	Use this before assigning plugins to tracks or effect slots.
Supported Instruments	Plugins that can act as MIDI track instruments.	These appear in the Instrument dropdown when Backend is VST3 Plugin.
Supported Effects	Plugins that can process audio as track insert effects.	These appear in both VST Effect dropdowns.
Manual classification	Override classification when you know a plugin role.	Use carefully; an instrument forced as an effect may not process audio correctly.
Failure details	Shows scan/load problems.	If a plugin disappears from dropdowns, check this first.

AudioClip Recorder window

Area	Purpose	Workflow notes
Target status	Shows the selected recording target and active sequence.	Make sure the intended track is selected before recording.
Format/quality	Chooses the media format for new takes.	Use WAV/FLAC for archival takes; compressed formats save space.
Mic gain	Adjusts input gain before recording.	Keep peaks below clipping.
Record controls	Record, stop, save/apply, redo, or discard a take.	Save / Apply attaches to the project in memory; Save Project commits it.
Track Live Effect	Monitor-only effect path through the first active track effect.	The recorded take remains dry.
Record Test	Short temporary recording test with automatic playback/cleanup.	Use before recording important takes.

Render Settings window

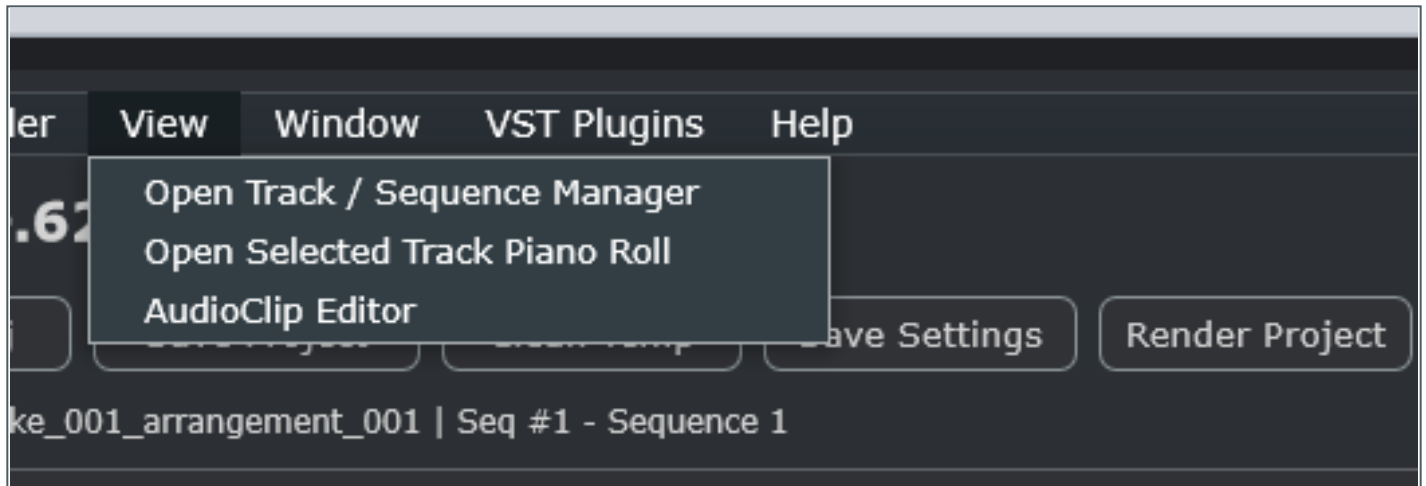
Setting	Purpose	When to use
Keep WAV stems	Preserve intermediate audio stems.	Debug a track or mix stems elsewhere.
Keep MIDI stems	Preserve intermediate MIDI files.	Inspect imported/converted MIDI track content.
Output cleanup	Control whether intermediate files are removed.	Keep the workspace tidy after normal renders.
Parallel/stem rendering options	Control render strategy where available.	Use defaults unless debugging performance or failures.

Window menu VST switchers

Menu area	Purpose	Workflow notes
VST Instrument submenu	Lists currently open VST instrument editor windows.	Use Window > VST Instrument when multiple instrument editors are open and you want to bring one track's editor forward.
VST Effect submenu	Lists currently open VST effect editor windows.	Entries use compact track/slot/plugin wording so slot 1 and slot 2 editors can be distinguished.
Piano Rolls submenu	Lists open Piano Roll editors when more than one is open.	The VST submenus follow the same window-switching idea as the Piano Roll window list.

Piano Roll Preview Player

View Menu: Opening Editors



View menu entries for opening Track Manager, the selected track Piano Roll, and AudioClip Editor.

The View menu provides another access path to the AudioClip Editor in addition to the main window and Track Manager buttons.

Use Open AudioClip Editor when the selected track is an AudioClip track. Use Open Selected Track Piano Roll for note-based MIDI editing. Track Manager remains the organization center for tracks and sequences.

AudioClip Editor dirty-close prompts protect pending source-trim edits only. Created arrangement tracks are normal project tracks and are handled by normal project save/discard behavior.

Area	Purpose	Workflow notes
Preview transport	Play a temporary Piano Roll preview render.	Useful for short phrase checks.
Preview file status	Shows whether a temporary preview exists.	Temporary preview files are not project media.
Cleanup behavior	Preview files can be removed automatically or by Clean Temp.	Do not rely on preview files for final exports.

21. Workflow Checklists

Use these checklists when testing a build or when confirming a project is ready to save/render. They are written as user workflows rather than internal build history.

Before saving a project

Check	Why
Project name/base name is correct.	Keeps .mwproj and output filenames clear.
Imported AudioClip tracks play correctly.	Confirms staged media is reachable before commit.
Recorded takes have been Save / Applied or discarded.	Avoids losing a wanted take or keeping an unwanted one.
Track settings have been applied after changes.	Ensures dropdowns, Enable, Bypass, mute/solo, and volume are saved.
Open VST editors have had Apply Changes clicked after parameter edits.	Captures plugin state into the project.
Preview sounds correct.	Catches missing tools, muted tracks, or wrong effect states before saving/exporting.

Before rendering final audio

Check	Why
Output format, sample rate, channels, and bitrate are correct.	Prevents accidental low-quality or wrong-format exports.
Muted/soloed tracks are intentional.	Solo left on can make final exports incomplete.
VST Effect slots show assigned + enabled + not bypassed where needed.	Only active slots process.
Save Project has committed wanted staged media.	Makes the project portable before final export.
A selected-track render has been tested for risky VST chains.	Catches plugin processing failures early.
The log has no unresolved error messages.	External tools and plugins report failures there.

Before discarding a project

Check	Why
No wanted imported audio is still only staged.	Discard removes the active staging session.
No wanted recording take is unapplied or unsaved.	Discard removes active unsaved project/session state.
Cancel rather than Discard if unsure.	Cancel keeps the current project and staging session active.
Use Save Project first if the media should be retained.	Save commits attached staged media to input\audio.

22. Detailed Setting Reference

AudioClip media settings

Setting	Values	Notes
AudioClip Format	WAV, FLAC, MP3, OGG where available	Controls imported/recorded stored media format where conversion is used.
Clip Quality	Bitrate choices for compressed formats	Ignored by lossless formats.
Channels	Mono/stereo render target	AudioClip source may be converted during processing/export.
Sample Rate	Common rates such as 44100/48000/96000	External tools and VST processing use render/request sample rates.

VST settings

Setting	Values	Notes
Max open VST windows	Configured limit	Prevents too many native plugin editors from being open at once.
Experimental acknowledgement	OK-only prompt	Shown from VST enable/open actions to remind users of plugin risk.
Graphics adapter preference	Compact numeric preference	Stored separately from the adapter cache list.
Plugin classification	Instrument, Effect, Warning, Unsupported	Controls where plugins appear in assignment dropdowns.

Render-output settings

Setting	Values	Notes
Output format	WAV, FLAC, MP3, OGG, MIDI depending on action	Final audio format is separate from AudioClip storage format.
Base filename	User-entered text	Used for final render names.
Export folder	Folder path	Defaults to workspace\exports.
Stem retention	Keep/remove options	Useful for debugging or external mixing.

23. Final Documentation Production Notes

This guide integrates the supplied screenshot set into the detailed guide structure. Contents and index links are active.

Future documentation feature	Current draft behavior
Clickable contents	Text contents list is present.
Clickable index	Text index is present.
Screenshots	Omitted for now to avoid stale visuals.
Button tables	Included throughout the guide.
Workflow examples	Included as step-by-step tables.

24. Glossary

Term	Meaning
AudioClip	A track/media reference for imported or recorded audio.
Bypass	Skip a configured effect while preserving assignment and state.
Dry	Source audio without printed effects.
Effect chain	Ordered slot processing: slot 1 then slot 2.
Offline preview/export	Temporary or final render path where effects are processed.
Project defaults	Template settings for future imported/new MIDI tracks.
Snapshot	Host-side saved plugin state slot for reuse.
Staged media	Unsaved-session audio media not yet committed to a saved project folder.
Supported Effect	A VST3 plugin classified for use in VST Effect dropdowns.
Supported Instrument	A VST3 plugin classified for use as a MIDI track instrument.
Track settings	Selected-track instrument, mixer, and VST effect-slot controls.